Etheria 571

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24671911.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warnings:
Major Character Death, Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F, F/M, Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Catra & Hordak (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra) & Original Character(s), Hordak & She-Ra, Hordak & Glimmer, Hordak & Princess Alliance (She-Ra), Hordak & Horde Prime (She-Ra), Hordak & Emily, Hordak & Wrong Hordak (She-Ra)

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Hordak, OCs, OC - Character, Entrapta, Sea Hawk, Emily, descendants of the main cast, She-Ra, Horde Prime, Wrong Hordak (She-Ra)

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English

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Part 2 of The Fate of Etheria

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Etheria 571

by Hag_of_Ages

Summary

Hordak lived a wonderful and fulfilling life with Entrapta and their children. Now they're gone. He's still here.

After sleeping for 500 years, Hordak wakes up to find that Etheria needs his help. The planet is being attacked by invaders and he's the only one left who knows how to wage war. Working alongside a clueless kid named Ordara, chosen to be the next She-Ra, Hordak finally has a chance to truly become the hero he never was. As he wrestles with his own past actions and how they have impacted the future, Hordak begins to doubt if there is any hope for him left.

Notes

When I published the first part of this saga, “The Prince who Slept 500 Years,” that was going to be it. I didn’t plan on publishing anything else ever again, mostly because I didn’t think people would bother to read it. That is, until, people asked for more. I had a few ideas here and there, I got bored, and suddenly here we are with me uploading more junk onto this website.

If you’re a fan of the first fic and you don’t want any potential good feelings ruined by an unnecessary continuation, you don’t have to read this at all. If you didn’t read the first part, that’s fine, I tried making it as easily accessible for all readers as possible. Just know that Hordak and Entrapta had a lot of babies before she died.

I also will incorporate a lot of flashbacks to the actual characters in the show. I don't want to have a story just be Hordak messing around with some OCs. Also, because I'm

trying to work in as much Entraptak fluff into everything I have.

tldr: Unnecessary? Yes. Diverting? Hopefully.

Escape from Beast / Robot Island

Year Zero ANS.

The gray clouds consumed everything in sight.

“Clouds” wasn’t the right word – the sky looked like one massive gray blob. Hordak hadn’t been to Beast Island in over twenty years, since he was first banished to this planet. Laying eyes upon it for the first time, he only saw ugliness. He had the audacity to call it “backwater.” Now, he knew there was so much more to Etheria. Now, he knew there was so much more to himself than the ugliness he once thought. Both this planet and himself were worth reclaiming, and he would do anything to earn his second chance.

But that didn’t stop his spine from shuddering at the desolate sight in front of him.

“Captain,” Hordak said, “are you certain we are on the right course?”

“Right as rain,” Sea Hawk replied, peering from a spyglass at the edge of the ship. “I see a wasteland of shadows, monsters, and everything in between – it can only be Beast Island!”

“Excellent,” Hordak grumbled.

Sea Hawk closed his spyglass and grinned at the former warlord. “It’s not too late to go back, if you’d rather see yourself in a dungeon for life.”

Hordak bit his tongue. That man’s senseless positive attitude and sing-songy voice was insufferable. But saying so out loud was not the way to make friends.

“No, thank you, Captain. I look forward to proving my worth with my own hands.” Hordak clenched his fists in a sign of

determination – something that once would have people shaking in their boots.

Sea Hawk blinked, unaffected. "All right! Also, you can call me Sea Hawk."

"Not because we are friends," Hordak questioned, doubting his ability to perceive Etherian customs.

The sailor laughed. "Of course not! Whenever you call me 'captain,' I can't help but think myself as a Horde soldier under your command."

Hordak gave him a half-smile. "That's fair enough."

The sound of whirring gears drew their attention away. Entrapta appeared on deck alongside Emily, who was carrying a load of heavy boxes on her hull.

"Blasters, check – ammunition, check," Entrapta listed off from a holo-pad. Not looking where she was going, she bumped right into Hordak. "Oof! Hey, lab partner! Emily's all packed and ready to go with everything we need for our vacation."

"You mean punishment," Hordak said.

"I don't see it that way," Entrapta said. "Sending us to study and collect data on Beast Island…"

"Eliminate monsters and scalp usable materials…" Hordak corrected, mimicking her tone of voice.

Oblivious, Entrapta rambled on, stars in her eyes. "They're basically giving us a scholarship, Hordak! And it'll be just the two of us. No silly princesses or politics getting in the way between us and pure science." With a giddy squeal, Entrapta latched onto his arm and swung him around.

Her enthusiasm was infectious. "Yes, with you at my side, we shall conquer Beast Island – " Hordak stopped himself. "I-I mean…help

Beast Island."

Entrapta kept staring up at him, not even catching onto him slipping into old habits. Her lips were spread into a simple smile, her eyes large and greedy, as if he was the only thing she wanted to look at. She hadn't stopped staring at him that way since they reunited after the war's end.

Hordak didn't know what else to do other than stare back at her and wonder what was happening to his face. Why did it feel so warm?

"Oh, uh…I've noticed you didn't pack any rations," Sea Hawk spoke up as he awkwardly shuffled away. "I'll go get you some. And leave you two alone."

Hordak, Entrapta, and Emily watched as the ruin of Beast Island pierced into view from the clouds.

Hordak knew redemption wouldn't be easy. It shouldn't be easy. But it would be foolish to treat this as a mere chore. With Entrapta at his side once again, hopefully the job would at least be fun.

For the first time in his life, Hordak was thinking about the future.

How exciting it would be.

Year 571 ANS.

The Sleeping Prince and the young She-Ra emerged from the ground and out into the world.

Hordak felt choked, and not just because his metal suit had rusted into a snare around his neck. He loathed to imagine the blisters and infections that were festering on his skin beneath. Yet, nothing could have been worse than emerging from his steel

bunker on Beast Island for the first time in five-hundred years. He was walking in a dream.

After their diligent work all those centuries ago, Hordak and Entrapta rescued any stranded prisoners of war, cleared out the monsters, and salvaged the most significant First Ones tech. The robots they invented to assist them in their mission were left behind.

"They'll be fine," Entrapta reassured him. Hordak could still hear her voice clearly in his head. He tasked himself to remember everything about her, even the insignificant banter. "They were programmed with the same autonomy and ethics of the average Etherian. Left to their own devices, they should build a wonderful little society of their own."

In a strange way, she was right.

Tall buildings lined the streets in a black city. Everything he saw was a metallic invention of some sort. Even the buildings were giant pieces of tech, as bright neon colors rippled up their sides. Bionic amalgamations of shapes Hordak couldn't even recognize crawled over every open space. On one corner, some humanoid-looking robots bowed to a giant statue of Emily.

"Um…Hordak?"

Hordak tore his eyes from Beast Island – or now as it was called, "Robot Island," and looked to the girl who awakened him from slumber.

"Yes, Ordara?"

The dark-skinned girl flinched at her name being spoken. She nervously ran her hands through her yellow hair. "Are…you're gonna follow me, right?"

"I need a moment." Hordak turned his head up as he saw ten tiny flying drones whizzing above his head. They crashed into each

other in a rhythm of five beats. The bionic forms below erupted in a mechanical applause.

Entrapta would have loved this, Hordak thought.

Ordara watched him, drumming her fingers on the sword of She-Ra at her side. "So, you really haven't been outside at all, have you?"

"Did you think it was a joke when I said, 'sleep until death took me?'" Hordak asked.

"Um…no, I think," Ordara mumbled.

Hordak sighed and reminded himself that she was just a girl. It had been ages since he had to deal with children, but he did raise eight of his own. Surely, he had to recall something about dealing with kids.

"Ordara, how far is it to your ship?" Hordak asked.

"Oh, yeah. Um…there aren't any ships. We use teleporters in Etheria now. They're everywhere, at least one in every major city of every kingdom."

"Teleporters?" Hordak asked. "But what if I only wish to travel a few miles?"

"We've got feet for that," Ordara answered.

"Are there no motor vehicles?" Hordak questioned. "In my time, I saw the invention of many different devices to ease the burden of travel."

"Long ago – but not longer than your long ago – one of the Queens of Bright Moon decided to outlaw vehicles. She said it made people too lazy."

"Then why with the teleporters…?! The world is backwards," Hordak muttered, gazing at his surroundings. "My wife envisioned

a culture of innovation and accessibility for all. Tell me, does the rest of Etheria look like this?" He gestured to the advanced tech that lined the streets.

"Nope," Ordara said.

"Wonderful." Hordak rubbed at his brow, feeling a deep headache beginning to form. He didn't know what to expect after waking up, but he knew it wasn't this.

"I like it here…" Ordara mumbled. "This is my home. I mean, not here here, I meant on the mainland."

This is what I have awakened to, Hordak thought to himself. A world of nonsense and an underdeveloped She-Ra with the spine of a jellyworm. I should have stayed asleep.

"The portal should be right…around…here!" Ordara took him to a corner, leading to a clearing that looked like a town square.

Hordak could see a wide disk plated with chrome. Several computers lined up around it, flashing with colors of smart green and red. He accepted just how miraculous a teleporter system on Etheria was. For a moment, he reminisced about his first real encounter with Entrapta – they discussed the portal that was designed to summon Horde Prime.

In the year 571, Etherians had not only harnessed the power of portals in a restricted way, but a philanthropic one. Hordak couldn't fight the feeling of pride budding in his chest as he imagined the brilliant and kind scientists who existed on this planet, carrying on his wife's legacy.

Three organic life forms approached the platform.

"Oh, looks like they're about to use it," Ordara said.

"How much energy does it have?" Hordak asked. "How many people can it carry?"

“The teleporters taps right into Etheria’s raw energy. But because it’s all contained in the same place, there’s nothing wasted. Energy just keeps getting borrowed. The power is limitless and it’s completely nature-friendly,” Ordara gushed. “Sorry if I blabber a bit, I really like science.”

“So you have told me.” To keep his mind from wandering back to the past, Hordak focused on what was in front of him. The three people were about to be transported to another spot on the planet. What a wonderful sight it would be to see!

The three strangers took out their weapons and began smashing the platform and blasting its computers. Hordak flinched at the waste.

“Is destruction of private property now legal in Etheria?” Hordak asked.

“No,” Ordara said. “Hordak, run!”

“Run?” Hordak looked back to the three who destroyed the teleporter. Etheria was a home to many different races of different sizes and shapes. These three, however, looked nothing like the creatures he knew on Etheria.

One of them, a glutenous giant with four arms, aimed a laser gun right at him.

Hordak ran after Ordara, gasping with pain as his rusted armor resisted his movement.

“You!” he barked. “Who are those three?”

The sound of laser fire erupted behind them.

“I think they’re some of the pirates!” Ordara shouted back.

“Whoever they are they just destroyed our way off of Beast Island!”

“It’s called Robot Island, remember? Gaah!” Ordara shrieked as a laser blasted right over her head.

With a painful effort, Hordak tackled Ordara and rolled the both of them under cover in an alley.

“My mechanics are useless,” Hordak said, beginning to dismantle his rusted armor, starting with the arms. He winced with pain as his raw flesh was exposed, burning bright with blisters. “Ordara, do you have any other weapons than the sword?”

“This is all I have,” Ordara said, drawing her sword of She-Ra. “Remember that queen of Bright Moon who outlawed all vehicles?”

“Yes?”

“She kinda outlawed all blasters, too.”

“Oh, for the love of…Well, Ordara, I at least hope that someone taught you how to fight.” Hordak had almost finished stripping away at his armor. All that was left was the chest plate and the pink computer chip that fastened it.

“I’m sorry, my dear,” Hordak whispered as he took out the chip and pocketed it. The rest of the rusted suit, he got ready to throw.

The first of the pirates rounded the corner, a wriggling mass of tentacles and a shadowy face. With a scream, Hordak lugged his rusted armor right into the hole where its face would be. They flew backwards, replaced by the other two pirates, the four-armed monster and a creature made of stone. Hordak threw his armor, but the first one caught every piece in his three other hands.

“Hyaaa!” Ordara came in while it was distracted, screaming as she swung her sword at him, slicing off two of his arms.

That left Hordak with the rock monster. Hordak got into a tight fighting stance, doing his best to summon all information on

hand-to-hand combat.

“You have no idea who you are facing,” Hordak taunted.

One swing from the rock monster’s face was enough to knock him out cold.

“Uh-oh!” Ordara yelped as she saw Hordak fly back ten feet. She turned back to her opponent, who had already sprouted back its two missing limbs. Not wanting to repeat the process, Ordara trusted her sword into her opponent’s big gut and let him fall over in pain. With a running start, she tackled over the rock monster, who fell with a heavy thud.

“The harder they are, the bigger they fall,” Ordara declared, stopping for a moment to slap her head. “Dang it, I said it wrong! Wait, I guess it still works…”

“Ughh…” Hordak groaned from the ground.

“Oh, right!” Ordara sheathed her sword and hoisted Hordak over her shoulder. He was surprisingly lightweight for his height. With a closer look, Ordara could see how emaciated and weak his limbs were.

Was this really the great man from the stories of old?

On the outskirts of the robotic city, Ordara dropped him. “Hey, Hordak, are you okay?”

“A…ship…” the man slurred.

“I already told you, there are no ships on Etheria,” she said. “Come on, keep up!”

“No, you simpleton,” Hordak spat. “They must have a ship! Those pirates!”

“Oh.” Ordara picked him back up. “Let’s go looking!”

“Get away from me,” Hordak shouted as he pushed her away. “I can walk on my own.”

“Can you run? We gotta find that ship fast!”

The broke into a sprint, circling the perimeter of the robot city. Everything else beyond was a gray wasteland. That made the ship easier to spot, as it reflected in the sunshine enough to blind them. It was a small cruiser, most likely constructed for short missions to and from local planets.

“This will do quite nicely,” Hordak said, satisfied.

Upon closer examination, he was disgusted by the poor condition it was kept in. Rusted panels, broken pieces kept together with tape, an engine that barely looked like it could power a microwave. Yet, something seemed familiar about its shape.

“Can you fly it?” Ordara asked.

“It seems I have no choice.”

Hordak and Ordara ran up into the ship’s hull. In the cockpit, Hordak made a quick study of all the buttons and mechanics.

“I recognize this type of ship,” Hordak said as he flicked on a few buttons, which he hoped were the start buttons. To his relief, the ship let out a warm purr as it began to hover.

“Ooh ooh ooh! Is it Darla?” Ordara asked. “Like the ship from the story?”

“This ship is not as nearly refined as Darla,” Hordak answered.

Hordak thought to himself, Over six-hundred years ago, I once colonized the race of people of whom this ship once belonged. This should be on the other side of the galaxy.

He punched a few more keys, muscle memory returning to him as he made his command. “Setting course for Bright Moon.”

The spaceship was in air, high above the gray and angular utopia of Robot Island. Hordak gritted his teeth as the ship whirred and shook, but eventually the old ship balanced itself out and began to glide evenly through the sky. It zoomed right towards the Valley of the Lost, and if all went well, they would soon be over the ocean.

Hordak released a stressed sigh of relief as he slid back on his chair. He needed a moment of quiet.

"Wow!" Ordara squealed. She pressed her face against the window. "I've never been inside a real ship before! Should we name it? I think we should name it Darla, just like from the stories."

The stories, Hordak thought. She's talking about my life like a story.

She wasn't wrong. Ages had passed since he once walked Etheria's surface as a man with meaning. Hordak's head fell back against his seat and he looked up at the ceiling of this spacecraft. He thought back to the beings they fought – the creature with four-arms, the creature of tentacles, the creature of stone. So distinct from other Etherians, but still somehow familiar.

Buried deep in his memories, memories he could never forget no matter how hard he tried, there was a time from when before Hordak had been a man of Etheria. Before he was a widow, before he was a father of eight rowdy children, before he was a lab partner – he was a soldier.

"Ordara," Hordak rasped, his chest heaving from the exhaustion from battle and the pain in his weak body.

"Yeah?" Ordara didn't peel her face from the window.

"Who are these pirates?"

Another War

Chapter Summary

Flashback to the unlikely friendship of Hordak and Catra.
In the present, Hordak gets to know the new She-Ra better.

Year One ANS.

Everyone had plans. Adora, Catra, Bow, and Glimmer all wanted to travel the stars before settling back in Etheria. Netassa and Spinerella wanted to adopt every single orphan on the planet. Frosta wanted to give up her role as a princess entirely so she could devote the rest of her days to mastering the art of combat. All Entrapta wanted to do was vanish back into her castle and resume her blissful life of machines.

Nobody got what they wanted. The war was over, but that did not guarantee peace returning the land. There were so many kinks in the system to work out and too many questions to answer, like, just what exactly were they going to do with the Fright Zone? Not to mention the giant population of Horde Clones who had nothing better to do than squat on their planet while they wrestled with sudden autonomy that they didn't ask for.

Nobody asked for any of this.

For those in power, finding solutions required many, many meetings.

With a wistful sigh, Hordak wandered the grounds. Every minute he would check behind him to glare at the guards that were not-so-subtly following his every move. The message was clear: he may have been a guest, be he was not welcomed. If it wasn't for Entrapta advocating for him, Hordak would have been ushered off the planet with the other Horde Clones by now.

He understood the Princess Alliance and their hesitancy to forgive him. He would have done the same, if the roles were reversed.

No, he probably would have been less forgiving. That was something he had to work on.

But this was a chance to change everything, to become accepted by the Etherians as one of their own. And if that meant a lifetime of being closely monitored, then Hordak would accept it gladly.

His only other option was to stay in his new home of Dryl, which was impossible, as Entrapta insisted she take him everywhere he went.

For his beloved's sake as well as his own, Hordak complied with the rules, even if it meant he never spent a minute alone.

The clone reached one of his favorite spots in the Bright Moon courtyard, a simple grassy area beneath a tree. He sat against its trunk and counted the leaves, counting himself a fool for ever wanting to do harm to the natural wonders of this planet.

"Think fast," a familiar voice hissed.

Hordak held up his arms to block as Catra leapt from her hidden spot on a tree branch. She bounced herself off of his armor and landed perfectly on her feet.

"Hey, old man," Catra greeted as she stood up. "Almost had you that time."

Hordak grinned at her. "You're lucky that you ended the war when you did. Another day, and Entrapta would've built me a suit with water cannons."

Catra shuddered at the thought. "What's stopping her now?" She plopped down cross-legged beneath the tree, soon joined by Meelog who sprawled out on her legs.

"Oh, the same that always stops us from doing anything," Hordak said as he returned to his own spot.

"Being stubborn and stupid?" Catra muttered.

“Duty,” Hordak answered. “You are not too far off with your answer.”

Out of everyone, Catra was the last person he expected to befriend. Day after day, however, they found themselves in the same position: left outside to wait as the princesses conjured up their plans. Hordak would never speak it out loud, but he believed there to be a deep bond between him and his former Force Captain. Nobody else had known what they went through together, even if it was ugly. Especially because it was ugly. Hordak did his best to banish such dwellings on the past.

“How is Adora faring?” he asked.

“Same thing I’ve been telling you for a year now. Busy.” Catra blew a strand of hair out of her face. “How’s the wrench wench?”

“Entrapta will always be Entrapta,” Hordak answered, nodding. “I would not have it any other way.”

Catra grumbled as she dug her claws in the dirt. “I keep thinking back to when they took me from Prime. Entrapta really wanted to keep exploring space. That’s probably never gonna happen now.”

Hordak thought it wasn’t just Entrapta she was talking about.

“If anyone deserves to enjoy a vacation from Etheria, it would be you and your friends,” Hordak said.

“Adora and Glimmer, maybe,” Catra said. “Me? Not so much.”

Hordak was about to ask her to elaborate, but Catra took advantage of the silence and began to rant. Hordak imagined she had it bottled up inside.

“They never give me the good stuff,” Catra said. “Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio got to clean up the Fright Zone. All the princesses are working on rebuilding just about everything else. Heck, you and Entrapta got to clean up Beast Island.”

“Did you want to deal with that wasteland of monsters and rogue tech?” Hordak asked, surprised.

Catra crossed her arms and fell flat on her back. “You know what I mean. I feel like they don’t trust me with anything.”

“That is a waste, I remember you to be a diligent worker.”

Catra snickered. “All I remember is you yelling at me.”

“You accomplished more than you ought to have,” Hordak said. “I was upset with you because on some level, I wished I was you.” He sealed his mouth shut, surprising himself with that revelation.

“Hordak…” Catra spoke carefully, “don’t tell anyone else I said this, but do you ever sometimes wish you could go back? And, like, not go back to change things, but to go back because you didn’t want things to change.”

Hordak thought a bit before answering. “I was a clone made in the image of a power-hungry and unforgiving tyrant. Because I was his clone, for so long, I thought that is what I had to be. A tyrant. All my flaws that made me unlike him had to be cast out. Until I met Entrapta. She taught me to appreciate my imperfections. I have been reborn, but I still carry with me memories of who I was in the past, who I was meant to be.”

“I get it, you love your tiny weird wife,” Catra said, flicking her tail in annoyance.

“She’s not my…” Hordak’s face flushed. “Should she be?”

Catra shrugged. “I dunno. Keep going. Don’t let me distract you.”

“Right. It’s not just about Entrapta. It’s about me.” He placed his hands over his chest, cradling his essence. “Instead of casting out my flaws, I can choose to cast out that which has bound me to the tyrant. Horde Prime tried to make me like him. But I can choose to let that go. Instead, I can be Hordak. Citizen of Etheria, humble inventor, proud husband who makes sure his wife attends

her meetings on time. Change is difficult, but it can be for the better. Even if nobody else knows it. I can change, and it is my opinion alone that matters."

"So…you're choosing who you want to be. And you just be it. And push away all the bad parts you inherited, and who cares if everyone else will still see you as a villain?" Catra's voice became strained. "Sounds too easy."

"I am probably making it sound easier than it is," Hordak said. "It is a challenge every day to be that version of me. But Entrapta reminds me. Even sitting out here in the grass is a reminder to not be the person I was before." He dug his claws into the soft, cool dirt.

The ex-Force Captain sat up. Meelong purred. "Do…you think that works for people other than clones?"

"Do you?"

Year 571 ANS.

Hordak tried to wrap his head around what he had been told. He and Ordara were still in the stolen ship, flying over the ocean to Bright Moon. The water below was a murky green, not the bright blue he remembered.

According to Ordara, the space pirates called themselves the "No-Homes." As the name implied, their home planters were destroyed or rendered uninhabitable. With nowhere else to go, they banded together and began pillaging resources from other planets. That explained the ragtag group of pirates from different planets, as well as the broken-down spacecraft they flew in now.

Ordara also told Hordak that it was speculated that many of the pirates had their planets of origin destroyed by the forces of Horde Prime, long ago.

“But that can’t be true,” Ordara said, sitting cross-legged in the copilot’s seat. “Horde Prime was a total pushover, right? In the stories, She-Ra Adora and the Princess Alliance defeated him easily. Horde Prime couldn’t have taken all of their planets if us Etherians could have defeated him.”

“You are wrong. Those stories do not contain the whole truth,” Hordak said, his back turned against her. He didn’t want to see the look of disappointment on her face when he told her. “Horde Prime was once the ruler of all the known universe. And I…I spent much of my early life helping him.”

“I know that, but in the story, you turned to the good side, so it’s okay, right?” Ordara asked, the tone in her voice asking him for a certain answer.

“Unfortunately, it seems not to be so. Those three that we fought on the island; I remember I was on the battlefield centuries ago when I took each of their homelands. Now, their descendants have come to exact their revenge.”

“Um, Hordak?” Ordara asked. “Does it really matter? Because, um…I really don’t care.”

Hordak looked back at the girl and titled his head. “Pardon me?”

“Yeah, I don’t care about revenge or the past, or whatever. I mean, that was hundreds of years ago and I’m only thirteen,” Ordara said. “All I care about is getting these pirates off my planet. That’s my job as She-Ra. So, can you help us or not?”

Hordak was astonished by her candor. He credited it to her youth.

She is right, he thought. No matter how many years I live, I never seem to learn this lesson. Live to make the future better, even if there is wreckage in your past.

Hordak crossed his arms behind his chest and stood with his back straight. Somewhere, buried deep in his mind, was Hordak the

Conqueror, an adroit military commander and trainer of soldiers. Maybe he could bring him back, this time for a good cause.

Maybe that would finally set things right.

"Over five-hundred years ago, Horde Prime was defeated once and for all by the power of She-Ra Adora. Ordara, are you ready to do what she once did?"

Ordara saluted. "Yes, Sir!"

Hordak's ears twitched unpleasantly at the sound of being called "sir," but if it got Ordara to focus, then he would play along.

"Tell me everything you know about the status of your powers."

Ordara shrunk. "Um…well, I already told you that I became She-Ra too soon, right? And my powers don't work the way I want them to."

"How did that come to be?"

"Last year, when the No-Homes first arrived, Queen Glimmer V of All-Etheria took the sword of She-Ra and passed it to ever girl in Etheria." Ordara winced a bit, as if tasting something bitter. Hordak assumed it was because Ordara considered becoming She-Ra a bad memory.

"There hadn't been a She-Ra since Adora. Etheria didn't need her. But when my hand touched the sword…" Ordara instinctively placed a hand at the weapon on her hip. "Everyone knew it had to be me. But I've never learned how to fight before or anything, people just keep looking at me like I have all the answers."

"I remember you mentioning you had two fathers," Hordak said. "What of them? Did they not teach you how to fight? Did they not advocate for you?"

Ordara looked down. "They, uh…they died when the pirates attacked our city."

“Oh.” Hordak dropped his commander persona as the sadness hit him. “I’m so sorry.”

“I’m kinda all alone now, except for my friend Princess Starella of Bright Moon, she’s gonna be the next queen. But even when I’m with her, I still feel like I’m alone.” Ordara kept her eyes glued to the ground, scratching at her arm. “I’m sorry, I kinda talk too much.”

Hordak couldn’t stop the feeling once it started. The last thing he wanted to do after sleeping for five-hundred years was to wake up and become attached to someone. When his dear Entrapta died, he gladly died with her. But this young girl, she was all alone. Her loved ones, all dead. Lofty expectations were placed on her small shoulders that still had barely finished growing.

“Lesson number one: you are never alone,” Hordak told her.

“Lesson…?” Ordara looked up with hope in her eyes, as if she knew what was coming next.

“Judging by your fighting skills, you possess much raw talent,” Hordak said. “As such, it falls upon me to teach you. Long ago, I once trained another girl who became She-Ra, but I failed her. I promise I won’t let the same happen to you.”

“Okay…okay!” Ordara cheered. “But I need to build you a suit, first. No offense, but I don’t think you can teach me anything if your body is gonna stay weak like that. I’m gonna go look and see if I can find some good scrap.”

Hordak watched her hop from her chair and rush to explore the rest of the stolen ship. He smiled, and he knew exactly what kind of smile it was. A proud smile, one that he once bestowed upon his own children.

Now, they were all gone. Theora, Umbral, Astral, Meteora, Excellcius, Xenona, Entangla, and Colbalta. Six daughters and two sons, lost to their own old age. Just like their mother. All that was left of them were their descendants who still roamed this planet,

carrying on their DNA. Hordak and Entrapta's strange, mixed-species DNA.

Whether Ordara herself was one of these descendants mattered not. She was a girl in need of a teacher, and that was all that mattered.

Hordak reached into the pocket of his slim trousers and took out the pink computer chip, his reminder.

"It seems Etheria is not through with me quite yet."

Queen of All-Etheria

Chapter Summary

> In the past, everyone is disturbed by a certain development between Hordak and Entrapta.
>
> In the present, Hordak has agreed to help Ordara and Etheria fight off the Space Pirates. But first they have to land the ship. Hordak's nightmare never ends.

Chapter Notes

> Yaaay for longer chapters! It's the least I could do for giving myself a whole week to prepare for uploads.
> Seriously though, when I first conceived the idea for this story, I imagined it to be three short chapters. Instead my fingers slipped on the keyboard and I made this. I hope you enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Year Two ANS.

The Princess Alliance had seen many forms of Hordak over the past twenty-two years. First, he was a ruthless conqueror, organizing the downfall of their planet for no justifiable reason. Next, he was a poor lost soul looking for a second chance, and if you couldn’t forgive him, you must have been a real bitter killjoy. In an alarming twist, he was soon Hordak the husband. But really, it wasn’t a huge surprise that he coupled with the strangest princess among them.

Even still, nothing could have prepared Etheria for seeing the latest version – Hordak the father. Or as Frosta called him, “Hordad.”

Hordak meandered through the halls of Bright Moon, wearing a harness that carried a squirming baby on his chest. Entrapta

refused to leave their sides, jotting down every single last diaper change or snot-bubble her baby blew.

"Day 136," Entrapta narrated into her tape recorder, "Test Subject #1 is displaying an accelerated growth rate compared to the average Etherian child, no doubt due to her father's DNA, whose own scans indicate genetic modification for a reduced infancy and extended adulthood."

Theora – as the child was named – was the first new princess to be born in years, ever since Frosta over thirteen years ago. Theora's arrival was a shock to everyone, but despite everyone's doubts, she was born healthy and thriving. She closely resembled Entrapta and could pass as a human, if it wasn't for her pointed ears. Etheria was already populated with a diverse number of species, so she would fit right in. Nobody spoke it out loud, but most felt relieved that she didn't inherit her father's bone-white skin and disturbing lack of a nose. Nobody felt more relieved of that fact than Hordak himself.

The rest of the Alliance insisted that Entrapta and her new "family" remain in Bright Moon for the first year, so that everyone could watch the new life grow. It was an example for the rest of the princesses to follow, after all. Bringing new blood into the royal families. Continuing on the legacy, so that the children centuries from now will remember their ancestor's names.

"Why…" Glimmer lamented, "why did it have to be Hordak's?"

The queen sat with Perfuma and Mermista, sipping tea as they prepared for the meeting on the status of improving their kingdoms' defenses. The three of them took a break from preparations so they could spy on Hordak and Entrapta as they stepped out into the courtyard.

"Don't ask me why, ask the geek," Mermista mumbled with a teacup at her lip.

It was sunny outside. The three of them held their breaths as they watched Hordak unzipping a pouch on the harness. He took out a tiny hat and placed it on the little princess' head to give her shade from the sun.

"This is a literal nightmare," Glimmer groaned, dropping her face on the table. "We were supposed to destroy Hordak, not make him part of the family!"

"I think they make a sweet couple," Perfuma said sympathetically. Glimmer and Mermista looked at her as if she had a cactus growing out of her mouth. "What?! Have you ever seen Entrapta this happy with another living, non-robot person?"

"If we made decisions based on what makes Entrapta happy, we would all be cyborgs by now," Mermista said.

"Test Subject #1 once again shows a behavior of restricted pupils when exposed to the outside sunlight," Entrapta continued to record, "indicating full-functioning eyesight. Anything else to add, lab partner?"

Entrapta extended the recorder to Hordak, who awkwardly cleared his throat.

"Test Subject Theora is small, soft, and has a look in her eyes that is difficult to describe in words…but it makes me believe she is an intelligent being." Hordak held his finger out in front of the baby, which she caught in her pudgy hands. "I did not think it possible, but I love this child even more with each passing day."

Meetings were made much more difficult after Princess Theora was born, as it was even more impossible to get Entrapta to attend. Before, they had to pry her from her inventions. Now, they had to pry her from her inventions and her baby. During meetings, Hordak took good care of the infant on his own with a little help from top babysitters, King Micah and Catra of all people. Micah's help was indispensable, being the resident father of the friend

group. Catra pretended like she helped only because she had nothing better to do.

After this day's meeting, Queen Glimmer excused herself five minutes early. She couldn't get her mind off of it. She knew something had to be done.

Glimmer went to the newly built nursery. She found her father and Hordak looking over Catra's shoulder as she changed a diaper.

"This is disgusting, I can't believe you tricked me into doing this," Catra hissed. Meelog growled with discomfort in the corner of the room.

"What are you talking about, you're a natural," Micah praised. "Babies love you."

"By the time you and Adora have children, you will be a master infant handler," Hordak said.

Catra's hair stood out on end. "I'm never having kids." She plucked the putrid poop rag, held it out as far away as she could, and walked it to the incinerator.

"Hello, everyone," Glimmer greeted, pinching her nose at the smell.

"Oh, Glimmer, you just missed the best part," Catra teased.

"Oh, boy, what a shame…" Glimmer made sure to sound as unenthusiastic as she could. "Hordak, may I speak with you for a moment?"

"Don't worry, Hordak, we got her," Micah said, holding the half-alien baby like a professional.

Hordak dipped his head in thanks. He followed Glimmer out of the nursery.

Out in the hall with no one else around, Hordak whispered to the queen, "If you want advice on rearing children, you are free to borrow our notes. Preferably my abridged version, Entrapta's would take too long to read."

"That is not what I…" Glimmer stopped mid-sentence as she actually began to think of the implications of what he said. "Wait, why would you think I want that?"

Hordak kept a straight face. "Pardon me, Your Highness, it is none of my business. What was it you wanted to tell me?"

"No," Glimmer insisted, "what are you talking about? Why would I want your notes?"

Hordak looked around to see they were alone. He lowered his voice. "You do know that you are with child, correct?"

"Wh…what?" Glimmer breathed.

"Entrapta noticed weeks ago. She's been hyper-sensitive to the symptoms ever since she endured her own pregnancy. Currently, we've been mapping the blueprints for a device that can scan expecting mothers to confirm a presence of an embryo…" Hordak's voice trailed off as he realized that the queen was no longer listening.

Glimmer looked away from Hordak's calm face. She placed a palm on her own stomach. A baby. She and Bow were having a baby. She felt a geyser of joy bursting through her chest. Oh, if only her mother was around so she could see this! She would've been so happy. Tears in her eyes, Glimmer looked back up to Hordak, whose own face had broke into a subtle smile.

"May I be the first to offer my congradulations," he said.

All that joy came crashing to a halt.

No, no, no, she thought, this isn't how I was supposed to find not. Not from him!

“You might think you’ve changed,” Glimmer said. “You might have Entrapta, Catra, and Perfuma convinced. You might even have yourself convinced. But even if you spend your entire life dedicated to helping us, you will never make things right. The damage you caused our planet is too great, and that will never be fixed.”

Hordak’s smile disappeared. “I know-”

“If you really want what’s best for Etheria, then you will leave as small of a footprint as you can. That includes the people you bring into this world.”

Glimmer made a sharp turn. She walked away.

Maybe it was mean of her to say those things. Hordak seemed completely aware of his situation. Was saying it out loud rude of her?

The ruler of Bright Moon tried to put those thoughts out of her mind. She was done being queen for the day. Ruminations of Hordak disappeared as she placed a hand over her quickening heart.

She couldn’t wait to see the look on Bow’s face when she told him.

- - -

Year 571 ANS.

Given the dramatic change to Beast Island, Hordak’s imagination went wild with how the rest of Etheria had changed. From the overhead view of the continent, he looked out in disappointment. It looked just as he left it.

Ordara wasn’t lying about the abolishment of conventional travel devices like air ships and motor vehicles. When the spaceship started to land, it began dropping on a civilian area, having no other proper landing platform to stop at.

“Pirates!” screamed the citizens of Bright Moon below as they began to attack the incoming ship. Giant lasers began firing into the sky in erratic but powerful beams.

Hordak knew those laser canons. He and Entrapta built them along ago to help bolster Etheria’s natural defenses after the war. He would have been touched by the fact that they were still in use, if not for the fact that they were aimed at him.

“Uh-oh,” Ordara said, scrambling to gather all her things. “Hordak, we gotta get out of here.”

Hordak hopped back in the pilots seat, trying his best to veer away from any attacks and change the landing position. The janky ship fought him, twisting his arms and swerving him enough to make him sick.

“Gaah!” Hordak asked as his muscles screamed at him to let go. He fell back into the seat, shaking.

I can’t fail now, I need to save that girl, he thought.

He turned around to see Ordara piling a bunch of scrap metal. At the side of the ship was a wide door, probably for emergencies like this one.

If they jumped, he could break her fall. He might even die on impact. Ideally.

“Ordara, there’s no time for that!” he said, taking her away from the scrap pile. He wasn’t strong enough to carry her, so he settled on dragging her by the arm.

“But I need it for your suit!” Ordara said. “Let go!”

Hordak marched to the door. “You can find tech elsewhere.”

“I can’t! There’s no tech left in-”

“Ordara, this is for your own good.” Hordak spotted a red lever and assumed it was the latch to open the door. He gripped it and pulled. It didn’t move an inch. His weak arms couldn’t do anything.

“Curses!” Hordak shouted, his mind racing for an answer. How could she get out of this ship alive?

They both screamed as a laser blasted right through the ship’s left wing. The whole vehicle began to spiral downwards, rattling them in the broken, metal belly.

Hordak heard a strange sound, one that he had almost forgotten. A shrill shimmer of light. He felt a hand on his arm and saw a glittering glow around him.

The next thing he knew, he landed softly an inch above the grass. Hordak looked up to see the ship crashing a mile away, leaving a corkscrew of smoke in the air.

“Ouch…” Ordara grunted next to him.

Hordak breathed a heavy sigh of relief that she was alive. Then he finally noticed they weren’t alone. Standing above him was another girl with tanned skin and jet-black hair that seemed to sparkle like the night sky, studded with stars.

“Starella!” Ordara gasped. She stood up and hugged the girl. “Why weren’t you here, like, five minutes earlier?”

“Sorry, want me to put you back in the rubble?” Starella grabbed her friend by the arm and the two vanished in a blast of glitter. They reappeared twenty feet in the air. The two girls fell out of the sky, Starella catching them again at the last minute, before finally appearing again on solid ground. They rolled on the grass laughing.

Starella, Hordak thought, Princess of Bright Moon. Descendant of Queen Glimmer and King Bow. Unoriginal naming conventions continued in the family, I see.

Still, Hordak couldn't help but feel his heart warmed at the sight. It was proof that life on Etheria moved on without him, strong and powerful, completely healed from the age of war long ago.

Then he saw the princess's pointed ears. His blood ran cold.

Oh no.

"Woah, Ordara," the Princess Starella said, "who is this guy and why does he look so much like my great-grandpa Teckgra?"

"Because he's your great-grandpa's great grandpa," Ordara announced. "I found him!"

Starella gasped. "Prince Hordak from the legends?!"

"Yeah!"

"Aaah!" Starella ran up and grabbed Hordak by the arm. "Hi Grandpa!"

"Unhand me," Hordak said firmly.

Starella slipped away obediently. "My apologies, Sir! Please forgive me."

Hordak glared at her, how quickly she retreated like a trained animal. "There is nothing to forgive. It seems we are family, after all."

Starella squealed. "I can't wait to show you to Mom!" On instinct, she reached out for Hordak and Ordara.

They transported again, this time landing in the great hall of Bright Moon.

Hordak lurched over, feeling queasy from the rapid movement. If he had eaten anything in the past five-hundred years, he would have thrown it all up.

"Mother, look, Ordara found him!"

Hordak twisted his dizzy head up to see a woman who looked like a grown-up version of Starella, dressed in regal gown.

“Starella!” the woman shouted, and her daughter immediately flinched. “What did I tell you about using your powers?”

“Only for emergencies, but this was an emergency! Ordara and Prince Hordak were in a falling spaceship-”

“Ordara? Prince Hordak?” The queen looked to each person respectively, her eyes widening with revelation. “Ordara, you disobeyed my orders and you are now grounded.”

“But Queen Vee, I-”

“No excuses! Go to your room immediately.”

“But Mother,” Starella joined in, mimicking her friend’s tone exactly, “she found help!”

“You are grounded as well. The both of you, leave my sight!”

The two girls turned their eyes to the floor, powerless. A pair of Bright Moon guards escorted them out of the hall.

Unusual, Hordak thought to himself as he observed the guards, their uniforms had not changed in five-hundred years…

Suddenly he felt tight in his throat and a deep ache in his bones. He coughed and gagged until he felt his lungs twist inside-out.

“Oh…my…stars…” the queen muttered. “Are you all right?”

“I’ll live,” Hordak grumbled. “I always seem to live.” He felt the weight of the day’s events drag him down. To awaken for the first time in centuries and be whisked away across the globe to meet strangers he only knew by long-lost ancestors.

Still, he made a promise. Hordak shakily stood himself up and looked into the eyes of yet another descendant.

At least this one is an adult, he thought. Maybe she will have the wisdom to leave me alone.

"Is it true?" the woman's brown eyes shined with wonder. "You are truly Hordak, the Sleeping Prince of legend?"

Hordak brushed his streak of blue hair back. "Please, just 'Hordak' is fine."

"Oh my…oh my oh my!" She clapped her hands together in quick succession. She seemed to remember herself, then bowed. "I am Queen Glimmer the Fifth of All-Etheria."

"All-Etheria?" Hordak asked. "I remember it being just Bright Moon."

"Oh, yes, there's so much you must know about the wonderful world of today." Queen Glimmer V tucked her hands neatly in front of her. "But first, is there anything I may do for you? Not only are you our most respected guest, but you are my own great-great-great-great-great-grandfather."

"Please, you mustn't," Hordak pleaded, his voice breaking a bit. "I am just here to help with your cause and rid the planet of invaders."

"Ah, of course. That clever girl, perhaps I was too harsh on her. This is exactly what Etheria needs, a hero of old rising again!" The queen lifted her fist mightily. "Perhaps you will educate us on the glorious past, and help us return to better, simpler times."

Hordak would have argued with her to the end of the earth. Before he could get a word out, exhaustion took him over, and soon his face was planted on the waxed floor of Bright Moon.

- - -

After fainting, Hordak woke up in a cushy room in a bed that was far too soft for his liking. He could hardly step out of it without having to swim.

Despite Hordak's orders, he was given a royal treatment. Attendants were at his command at all times. He was given freedom to walk everywhere in Bright Moon, as well as his own personal quarters. It was suffocating. Was it really not long ago that he was an alien? A war criminal who everyone reluctantly accepted? Now, we was "a hero of old," a founding father who deserved the best treatment.

Hordak had to admit, despite the claustrophobia it gave him, it was better than being treated like an outsider.

If there was one luxury he was most grateful for, it was the fact that everyone patiently explained everything to him and answered all of his questions.

At the end of the first day, he walked through the halls of Bright Moon, engaging in a private conversation with Queen Glimmer V. His armor was not ready for him yet, so both of his arms had to be kept in slings across his chest. For his own comfort, he was flanked by two guards sworn to secrecy.

If someone told the old Hordak that one day he would be treated as a cherished grandfather by the Etherians, he would have split his own head open with a laser.

"The No-Homes, as they are called, appeared one year prior. They began invading smaller districts and towns, as if they were only picking away at the easy targets," the queen told him. "As of late, they have begun sieging larger cities, destroying lines of communication and transportation. They don't wish to defeat us by destroying at our resources, as is expected for classical warfare, they would rather directly kill our population and take the resources for themselves. As you can imagine, this makes them very dangerous to fight."

"Hm, pirates indeed," Hordak agreed.

Hordak stopped in his tracks to gaze upon a mural depicting She-Ra Adora, the other members of the Princess Alliance, and even

Catra and Bow. The first thing Hordak did was search for Entrapta, who was depicted with a triumphant wrench held high in the air. Hordak smiled as he lifted his right hand from its sling. It trembled with pain, but it all seemed to went away as he grazed his hand across the picture of her.

His eyes traveled to the figure standing next to her. He pulled his hand away as he realized it was a picture of him.

His granddaughter joined him by his side, admiring the work.

“This mural was commissioned after she passed,” Queen Glimmer V said. “With all the princesses gone, they rushed to have a mural to immortalize them so no one would forget.”

“It is a nice piece. However, looking at this artwork, it almost makes me think you believe me to be as equal to them,” Hordak said.

“I know who you are,” the queen said, looking at the other figures in the picture. “I know who all of you were. Princess Entrapta spent a majority of the Horde War helping the fight against the Alliance. Lady Catra was a war criminal, responsible for the death of Queen Angella the First. Queen Glimmer the First was not so innocent herself.”

“Is this not common knowledge?” Hordak watched with curiosity as she shook her head. “Then how do you know of this?”

“I have their records. In fact, I’m the only one who has access to them.”

“Why not share the records with everyone?” Hordak asked.

The queen sighed. “The world is full of darkness enough as it is, why should our past be as dark as the present?”

Hordak had an answer, but a shout sounded before he could put it into words. The two adults turned their heads to watch as Starella and Ordara chased each other in the grass outside.

Queen Glimmer V snarled. “I thought I grounded those two.”

“I’ve raised enough children to know that the more you try and force them into place, the more they act out. That Ordara…is it true she is an orphan?”

Queen Glimmer V nodded. “After discovering she was the next She-Ra, I had no choice other than to take her in as my own.”

“I see,” Hordak said. “And what have you done to train her for her destiny?”

“I have been patient. Which is important, as there is not near enough patience in this world.” The queen returned to walking down the path away from the mural. “My family was always patient, and their patience has rewarded me with your presence, Grandfather.”

Hordak took one last look at the picture of him and his long-dead wife, immortalized forever.

“They did not need me,” Hordak said, following her. “But now it seems you do. If you grant me the power, I promise I will militarize Etheria into a force that will rid the planet of those pirates.”

Hordak did not see the queen’s face as she spoke next. “I look forward to judging what you deliver to me.” She turned around, arms slightly outstretched. “Would it be too much to ask for a hug, Grandfather?”

So many years had passed, Hordak severely doubted the significance of their common blood. But it would have been rude to refuse a hug. Nobody ever wanted to hug him before.

- - -

Ordara’s fingers drummed in anticipation as she waited for Hordak to step out of the room.

“How’s it fitting?” she shouted.

“That is the fourth time you asked me.”

“Because you’re not telling me anything!”

On the other side of the door, Hordak sighed. He looked into the mirror one last time. The suit she built for him was not even close to the finesse of Entrapta’s original design. It was clunky and uncomfortable, but Hordak attributed that to the poor quality of scrap metal Ordara took from the fallen ship. Apparently, proper scientific equipment was made difficult to come by. The more Hordak learned about Etheria in the year 571, the list of banned innovations became longer and longer.

Then there was the actual handiwork itself. The measurements weren’t accurate, so the suit pinched in some areas and left sweaty gaps in others.

Think positive, Hordak thought. She’s just a child, after all.

The suit kept his arms strong. The careful inclusion of Entrapta’s computer chip breathed life into the entire mechanism.

Finally, Hordak put on the regalia that the queen gave to him. Tight-fitting armored trousers with a grand cape that dramatically swept behind him. He looked ridiculous. Pathetic, even, as he felt like the dictator he wanted so badly to be six-hundred years ago. This is what Etheria wanted, apparently. Wearing it was the least he could do for these people.

“It is suitable,” Hordak said as he stepped out of the room.

Ordara’s head dropped. “You hate it. You can just say it.”

“I don’t hate it,” Hordak said, exasperated. “You did an excellent job incorporating the computer.” Instinctively, he touched the pink chip at the apex of the armor.

“I’ve been begging Queen Vee to let me study some of Princess Entrapta’s work,” Ordara said, brightening up a bit. “She said that maybe she will, so I can build you a better suit.”

“For your age and skill level, it is quite impressive. What brought you interest in tech? Was it the stories of Entrapta’s inventions?”

“Yeah, of course!” Ordara said. She scratched her yellow hair. “But also because…well…I’ve always wanted to build a suit of my own. A whole new body.”

“Curious. Whatever for?”

“Um…because it would be fun?” Ordara said, shrugging.

Hordak accepted that answer. “Perhaps I can share with you what I know. But first, we have a planet to save.”

- - -

Five-hundred years into the future, Hordak found himself standing outside the entrance of one of the few rooms of Bright Moon whence he never walked before. The war room. He took a deep breath and held in his gut as the door opened.

The long table was filled with members of the Princess Alliance – or as it was now called, the Noble Alliance. While the occupants of the table were those in charge of the old kingdoms like Plumeria, Salineas, and the Fright Zone – they were not princesses. Instead, they called themselves Duchesses. And their kingdoms were no longer called kingdoms, but rather “domains,” all under the reign of Queen Glimmer V.

“Our kingdoms were united, and now the people of Etheria are closer than ever,” she had told him.

Hordak liked the idea. After all, the regents still retained all the same power they did centuries ago.

The members of the alliance stood in attention as Hordak stepped into the room.

“Ladies and gentlemen of the alliance,” the queen announced, “please join me in welcoming Hordak, Prince of Dryl and hero of old.”

Hordak winced as the words scraped his ears. As he walked to his seat, however, he couldn’t help but notice the look of reverence in their eyes. The rulers of Etheria, descendants of people who once thought him a villain, now hailed him as their hero.

Hordak could not deny it any longer. They truly believed in him.

On his walk to his reserved seat in between the queen and She-Ra Ordara, Hordak made particular eye contact with the purple-haired duchess of Dryl. Just this once, he allowed himself to give her a fatherly smile of recognition.

When they reached his spot, they all sat down except for him.

“Ordara,” Hordak mumbled out of the corner of his mouth, “you’re not supposed to sit yet.”

“Oh, sorry!” Ordara tried to whisper but ended up hissing so everyone could hear. She scrambled back up to her feet.

Hordak cleared his throat and hardened himself for what came next.

“I have a plan for taking back our planet.”

Chapter End Notes

> When I started writing this, I had no idea that Bright Moon royalty would also be Entrapdak descendants. The idea came to me as soon as I was writing it. I think it's for the best, honestly. I'm done writing like 65% of this whole thing and I keep surprising myself with all the absurdness I'm coming up with.

Also, "Queen Glimmer the Fifth" = "Queen Glimmer V" for short. That's also where she gets the nickname "Queen Vee" from Ordara. Yay for Roman numerals.
Anyways, thanks for sticking with me!

Temple of the Past

Chapter Summary

> Once upon a time, there was a Horde Clone who was a monster, because that is all he was told to be.
> In the present, the same Horde Clone is asked to be a leader. He does what he can.

Chapter Notes

> ANNOUNCEMENTS:
>
> When I started this project, I decided I would upload one chapter a week to give me time to finish / edit chapters as needed. I can now say that I'm actually done with all the writing! Instead of keeping it to every Thursday, I'll be uploading every day until completion of the series. More on that later.
>
> Second announcement, this chapter is a bit...different from the others. The fight scene is a tad bit more on the violent side. Nothing too awful, but I'm adding an archive warning just to be sure.

You are a humble farmer living on a planet so small that it has no name. You and the rest of your kind call yourselves “pallows.” Your body is mostly made of wood and bark, as you evolved from trees, not flesh. Long white hair flows down your backs, and leaves grow from your joints. Your kind were once predators, hunting the small furry creatures that burrow in the red earth.

Nowadays, you and your people build huts out of grass and harvest squash. You don’t hunt anymore.

It’s close to sunset. The season has been blessed with warmth, but not too warm enough to make you sweat through your root-feet. You give your blessings to the Eight Gods as you walk on the soft dirt road home.

Your long nose smells something. Smoke. Your yellow eyes flick up. A tower of black smoke is climbing through the air.

Wait. Your whole body stops and refuses to move. That smoke is coming from…

Home.

Your legs run as fast as they can. You rise over the hill and you can't believe what you see. You refuse to believe it.

The village where your family lives, where your neighbors live…it's all been set aflame. A tremendous whirring noise floods the air, whips up wind that tears through your white fur. You look up to see something giant flying through the air, pouring fire and other small objects that crash-land onto your land. The giant flying object soars over your head in the direction of the squash harvest.

You choose your family first. Your mother, your father, your seven younger siblings. They are all you have and all that you are.

You roll yourself downhill into the valley because it's faster than running. The grass was once green like gemstones, but it now flooded in a haze of orange flames and black smoke.

You call out your parents' names, not even recognizing the streets you grew up on. The homes that housed your friends. The place where you were born.

You can't believe it. It's as if there's a dam in your brain that refuses to let you know the truth. Everything you ever knew and loved is gone.

You shout their names. You beg for any sign of life that they might be okay. Your siblings looked up to you so much, you always imagined yourself to be the one to run in and save the day if they needed help.

There they are, in the house, burning.

And yet you can’t move.

Footsteps. Your ears flick, and then your eyes follow. Towering before you is the largest being you had ever laid eyes on. For so long, you and your kind were the predators, the masters of this land.

This…this creature was not of this land. An alien. It stood on two muscular legs and two silver arms that spat fire. Its skin was a deathly white. No nose, sharp ears. Its green eyes glowed at you like ghosts in the night.

In its claw, it holds a limp body. The body of your youngest sibling.

The alien throws the body aside. It points its arm, and a tongue of flame shoots out of a canon. Your little sibling’s body is burned all away.

The alien turns its fire-canon onto you.

“Do not be afraid,” it speaks to you, “you must be cleansed for the sake of Horde Prime. It is an honor.”

The breath of fire chases you as you turn and run. You run as fast as your legs can carry you, long past the point of pain in your roots. You don’t stop until you jump into the river outside of town. The water carries you away in an unforgiving current, but it’s slow enough to give you a perfect view of the valley as it burns.

Finally, you are given the chance to feel.

You cry. You mourn. You curse the gods and ask them why they allowed such a massacre to happen.

You stop crying. You begin to wonder. Who are these otherworldly creatures? Who was this “Horde Prime” they spoke of?

You cry again. These creatures were monsters. They attacked a peaceful people and slaughtered their children.

A great light explodes in the air, and for a few moments, an insignia is lighted upon the sky. Two wing-like symbols branching out of a diamond. Victorious cheer erupts from the destruction in voices you do not recognize. They celebrate the death of your family and your life.

Your heart becomes corrupted, filled with anguish and hatred that one body cannot carry.

When you have children, they will inherit this hate, just as they inherit the yellow of your eyes.

- - -

You are a Horde Clone. Horde Clone D5639-AK, to be exact. Not that it means anything. Only Prime is worthy enough to be given a name, after all.

Secretly, you believe you are special. You are younger than most other clones, yet you have already distinguished yourself as a warrior.

Right now, you stand in a pile of ash. Your message to the plant-based inhabitants of this tiny moon has been relayed clear: they now stand in the property of Horde Prime.

Your bone-white skin shivers at the thought. Your white streak of hair stands on end. The power, the majesty, the beauty of Horde Prime. Cleansing this backwater solar system and delivering it to serve a greater purpose.

And you are a part of it.

You dust your hands off of the ash. You kick over a half-burning body whose hand is outstretched for help. You are cold, ruthless, and effective. The way like He programmed you to be. Just like Him. Your beloved Older Brother.

Before ascending into the ship, you give the order to one of your subordinate brothers: light the fuse. As you rise into the ship, you

see the explosion above the smoke, setting the black cloud all aglow. The Horde insignia.

You take your time in cleaning yourself up, wiping away all imperfections. Every patch of soot you carried with you, every rip or tear in your white cloth. Once you are beautiful again, you are given permission to enter His chambers.

His Excellency is difficult to look upon. Words can't even begin to describe Him. Immaculate. Enlightened. Exalted. No…mere words have no power among him.

Your pulse quickens to abnormal rates. You kneel before Him. Filthy sweat gathers at your palms, which you pin to the ground in submission.

"And how was your trip to that moon, Little Brother?" Prime's voice dripped down the walls of the chambers, sweet and intoxicating like the fluids in the birthing tube you emerged from. Your eyes stay on the polished floor. You see your own reflection: the gaunt face, the sharp ears, the green eyes, all like him. Wait, is that…a strand of blue coloring? On your hair?

You look away from yourself. You will fix that later.

"The Moon AGB-002 is not nearly as technologically advanced to Your genius," you answer. "Its denizens are peasants, easily subdued. Easily burned away."

"Have you claimed this moon in my name, Little Brother?" Prime asked with high authority, already knowing the answer.

You allow yourself just one small look at him. You lift your head just enough to see His shapely legs, crossed in a lax position.

"Yes," you answer.

Prime hums in delight. His legs move to sand. He steps closer to you. Your heart is overflowing with joy. You feel his cool claws

graze across your cheeks. He tilts your gaze up, and you see his pleased smile.

"Good," He purrs. "It seems promoting you to Force Captain was not a mistake. Continue to prove me right."

"Yes, Lord Prime," you gasp, choking on your own words.

He gives you a reaffirming pat on the cheek. He steps towards the window, giving Him a perfect view of his domain below.

"Come, Force Captain D5639-AK," he says. You shudder with delight because He remembers your number. "Look upon the glory you have given to me."

"All glory comes from You," you say. It's a reflex you learned in conditioning.

Something's not right. You move to push yourself back to your feet and walk to his side. Instead, waves of pain ripple through your arms and your spine. Your arms…no, they can't be shaking! You are strong and powerful, made in His image.

"Little Brother," He says, "don't make me repeat myself."

Biting through the pain, you force your weak body up. Something is clearly wrong with you. It must be the jitters from standing so close to Prime. Yes, that's it. You banish all worries and bask in the tiny light you are given from Prime's glow.

You don't know it yet, but some day, you will succumb to your DNA defects. Horde Prime will cast you out. You will feel lost, devastated, knowing you would be better off dead.

Then you will keep making yourself in his image. In the backwater planet you will be banished to, you will try and build an empire of your own, a legacy of your own. You will rage war on the people of that planet.

You will start to feel pity for the world you uproot, but you stop yourself, tell yourself that "Prime would not approve of this emotion."

You will raise child soldiers. All orphans, they will look up to you with reverence and fear. You will start to care for them. But you stop yourself. "Prime would not approve of this emotion."

You will meet someone who changes your mind about everything you have ever known. She will give you confusion emotions, which you start to identify as love. "Prime…Prime would not approve of this emotion. He would never."

One of these days, you will learn how to live a different way than how you were taught. You will learn to live for yourself, not another person's selfish expectations. In fact, you will learn that what you truly want isn't what you thought.

Far from it.

You will learn one day that you were wrong about so many things.

But not today. Today is the day you stand at His side, flushed with honor and love for Him. Conquering worlds and claiming them for your Creator and Elder Brother. Paying no heed to lives you destroy. Not caring about how others see you.

A monster.

- - -

Year 571 ANS.

The plan was set. In one fell swoop, Hordak would not only mobilize the Etherians and give them the means to fight, but they would strike back against the pirates in a race for the planet's resources.

But that was days from now.

Hordak was not sure what to expect after waking up in the future, but one thing for sure, he didn't expect to feel this relaxed.

Queen Glimmer V of All-Etheria gave him a box full of what she called "old relics." All Hordak saw were his things. Technically, Entrapta's things.

For the first time in a lifetime, Hordak heard his beloved's voice again. He sat in the corner of the guest room in the castle listening to playback after playback. Interestingly enough, none of the recordings were of her inventions or theories. Most of them were diary entries from different points in her life. Some of them, Hordak never even knew existed.

Whenever he wasn't clammed up in his room, engorging himself in the nostalgia, Hordak forced himself outside. He couldn't walk anywhere alone, as he was soon flanked by his descendants, people curious about the world of the past, or both.

Hordak tried to keep up a stoic appearance. He wasn't about to let himself become attached to this world, not more than he already had. That changed when the regents of Dryl presented him with great-great-great-great-great-great-great-grandchildren.

The bloodline had thinned so much, there was hardly any resemblance left in the offspring of his offspring.

Still. Their enthusiasm to meet him was enough to melt all the ice in Hordak's heart.

He ran through the courtyard of Bright Moon, letting the flock of children chase him around every tree and bush. When he finally let them catch up to him, he thought he would have to pretend to fall. He didn't have to. They forced him to the ground, dragging him by his limbs.

From behind a pillar, Ordara watched.

"Um…Hordak, Sir?" she called out, careful not to raise her voice too loud. He didn't respond.

“Unhand me!” Hordak screamed as the children giggled.

“You’re so weird, Grandpa,” his granddaughter said.

“You look funny!” His grandson stuck a finger through Hordak’s nasal cavity.

“Stop that.” Hordak said, brushing the boy’s hand away and fighting back a sneeze. The little boy grabbed onto his pointed ears instead.

“Hordak,” Ordara called out, louder this time.

“You wild savages,” Hordak said, emerging from the dogpile and grabbing one of them by the ankle. They screamed and laughed at him. In his most dramatic voice possible, he declared, “I ought to banish you to Robot Island.”

“Hordak!” Ordara screamed. Everyone in the courtyard had their eyes on her, wondering why this random kid was interrupting everyone.

“Ordara.” Hordak gingerly placed the squirming child back on the grass. “Is there something you need from me?”

“Uh…I thought you were gonna teach me about being She-Ra.” Ordara awkwardly lifted her sword like it was a branch broken from a tree. “Or something. I guess you don’t have to.”

Blushing, Hordak cleared his throat and excused himself from his many descendants. He and Ordara walked towards one of the training halls in Bright Moon.

“My apologies, Ordara,” Hordak said. “I had forgotten what it was like to be part of a family, and the excitement overcame me.”

“Yeah,” Ordara grumbled. “Must be nice.”

Hordak, you cruel old fool, he thought.

Wincing, Hordak reminded himself to focus on what was ahead. Etheria's safety, Ordara's training.

"Ordara," Hordak began when they arrived at the training room, "I must admit that I know very little of the origins of She-Ra's powers. From observation and my own personal study, I have noted that the power of She-Ra is often drawn based on the emotions of the host."

Ordara's eyes opened a bit with understanding. "Oh, you mean like in the legend, how She-Ra Adora finally stopped Horde Prime with true love's kiss?"

"You are correct, but you must stop referring to history as legend." Hordak shook his head. "As saccharine as it sounds, true love and friendship saved Etheria. With that in mind, I ought to learn your story better." Hordak stepped over to a training dummy, tipped it over, and used it as a chair. He sat there staring until Ordara caught on and knocked down a chair down for herself.

"My story?" Ordara asked, uncertain.

"Yes. Adora could not master her powers until she mastered herself. If we are to figure out the issues with your powers, we must know exactly who we are dealing with."

Does she understand? Hordak thought. His suspicions were confirmed by Ordara's face twisting into an uncomfortable frown.

"The story of my life has become a fairy tale for all of Etheria," Hordak elaborated. "I have spent the past few days having my brain picked about my life. I would like to not be the one having a picked brain for once."

"Oh, I think I get it," Ordara said. "Well, um…there's not really much I can say about me. I've had a boring life."

"'Boring' does not necessarily mean 'unworthy,'" Hordak said. "The happiest days of my life were when I was a housebound husband

and father. I would always choose that boring, lovely live over the life of a warlord."

"That's kind of lame, but I guess that makes sense," Ordara said, smiling again. "I guess my life has been boring too, but in a good way. My dads were both teachers of history and literature. That's why they were geeky about fairy tales, and they told me a lot when I was a little kid. They taught at a school in Bright Moon, but we lived in a house in a small village outside of Bright Moon. The house was green on the outside and inside, because the roof was a weird olive-green color, and the inside was full of plants. My dads really liked plants. We even kept a garden."

Ordara's mouth shut, and she self-consciously looked up at Hordak. "Is this any good?"

"Keep going," Hordak said.

Ordara nodded. As she talked, she curled her yellow hair on her finger back and forth. "I told you they're dead. Pirates came last year and attacked the whole village, killed anyone who tried to stop them. I didn't actually see them get…you know. Some kids had to watch their parents die in front of them. And I mean… really young kids, younger than me. I guess you should say I was lucky because I didn't have to see it, but sometimes I wish I did." Ordara gasped. "I don't actually mean that…it's just that they never came back, so part of me still won't accept that they are dead. I keep expecting them to walk around the corner like they've been looking for me."

"Tell me about She-Ra," Hordak said, hoping to lead her back to a positive mindset. He didn't mean to bring up distressing memories, but it was important to have a full scope of her emotions. They were talking about the source of her powers, after all.

Ordara winced. "A lot of us who had lost our homes, we were pushed into Bright Moon. One day, some people were passing an old sword around." Ordara tapped a sword on her left hip.

Hordak knew that sword. It was somewhat similar to the sword Adora broke during the time of war. Ever since then, Adora had a revelation that the powers did not rest in the sword but were inside her. After her passing, however, it was necessary to place that power back into an object. She-Ra would rest dormant in the sword until Etheria would call upon her again.

Hordak tried not to think about Adora's funeral. It was difficult to stop once it started. He had sat through many in his lifetime but remembered each of them so well.

"I apologize, Adora, could you repeat that last sentence for me?" Hordak asked.

"Ordara," the girl across from him said.

"Right. Ordara. My apologies." Hordak wished he could bite his tongue out.

"It's okay, I was thinking of changing my name anyways. Anyways, um," Ordara cleared her throat, "they passed the sword around to every girl or woman. It was my turn, and I wasn't even thinking about it, but suddenly it started to glow. I was covered in light everywhere. Everyone started to bow to me like I was the queen. Soon I even saw the queen! She invited me to live in Bright Moon and said she'd take care of me while we work on my powers."

"And how has that been?"

"Well, I can make the sword glow, but I can't actually turn into She-Ra." Ordara ran her thumb on the edge of the blade. "I thought I was a failure. Until Queen Vee – that's what I call Queen Glimmer V – until Queen Vee told me about some ancient weapons that I could activate with my power. I don't even have to be She-Ra really, to do it."

"Ancient weapons?"

"Like the Heart of Etheria," Ordara said.

“Absolutely not,” Hordak nearly shouted, placing extra emphasis on the word “not.”

“Why not?”

“It is far too dangerous. That is a power not even my wife could fully comprehend, even after years of research. And I’ll have you know,” Hordak said, “my wife was brilliant.”

“I know,” Ordara said. “I wish we could use some of her inventions.”

Hordak sighed. As much as he was indulging the attention from Queen Glimmer V and her court, he had a growing list of qualms with how they were running Etheria, especially when it came to distribution of technology. Hordak pushed it aside for now and returned to focusing on what was in front of him.

“She-Ra Adora was most effective in her full state of power. That power was activated by necessity and nurtured by her connections with her friends and the other elemental princesses. But her powers never became fully realized until she found inner strength.” Hordak stood up and waited for Ordara to do the same. She was a quick learner.

“Hold your sword aloft,” Hordak instructed. “Now, close your eyes. Feel the power buried deep within the sword, a mere extension of yourself. Can you feel it?”

“Yeah, I think.”

“No peeking,” Hordak said when he saw her open an eye to check the sword. “The outside world is unimportant. Focus on your inner world. Your memories. What makes you smile. The green house full of planets, your fathers, the people who loved you. They never stopped loving you, that love still exists as long as you are alive.”

Hordak wasn’t sure if this method of harnessing emotions would work. To his relief, he saw the sword glow brighter than before.

He saw a small, happy smile grow on Ordara's face.

Hordak even closed his own eyes to do the practice for himself. He was in the throne room of Castle Crypto, dark and quiet, glowing with screens and monitors and energy pulsing through the very walls. Entrapta had her hands full with a new invention and was repeating his name over and over again, trying to get his attention, trying to ask him to hand her a power drill.

Even though he really was standing in a training room in Bright Moon, centuries away from home, he still felt a warm glow around him as he pictured it.

I am a genius, Hordak thought. He imagined himself telling his wife, Who says I have the emotional depth of a toilet bowl? He could hear her screechy laugh, just before talking over him and going off about a rant on whatever unrelated idea that was in her mind at the time.

"Ordara, that love you feel is your power. Now, with that power, take up your sword and make it yours."

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

Even as Hordak's eyes were closed, he detected a bright flash on the other side of his eyelids. He opened them, expecting to see a fully-realized She-Ra in all of her long-haired and shining glory.

Instead, Ordara had dropped the sword and rubbed at her face.

"Owowowo…" she mumbled. "I hurt my eyes."

They continued the process for another hour at least. No matter how hard he tried to coach her on thinking positive, that couldn't connect to her turning into She-Ra.

"I'm starting to think, do I really need to be She-Ra?" Ordara said during a break. "I mean, I still got a huge sword. I can cut some arms off with it as She-Ra or not."

A servant entered a few minutes earlier and offered them both refreshments.

“It’s more than just the sword,” Hordak said, ironically relishing in the fact that he was a 800-year-old man drinking out of a sippy cup. “She-Ra is an icon. A leader. When people look to her, they have an instinct to follow.”

Ordara mumbled something incoherent.

“A leader,” she continued after a silence, “that’s kinda what I woke you up for.”

“She-Ra will always be Etheria’s beacon of hope,” Hordak argued. “After training and experience, you will do a much better job at inspiring the masses than I ever could.”

“But Hordak…”

“Yes?”

“What are you even gonna do when the war’s over? I mean… you’re gonna stay, right?”

Hordak’s drink nearly slipped from his claws. It was a good question. He hadn’t thought of it before.

- - -

The night before the attack they planned, Hordak snuck away from his adoring crowd to snoop around the castle.

If only Ordara equipped my suit with a proper scanner, he thought as he focused on stepping without sound. No, no, I shouldn’t ask too much of her. She’s had enough trouble in her short life as it is.

In the end, it meant that Hordak had to face a lot of trial and error. Opening doors, sneaking past guards, pulling books from the library to find a secret lever. One that would hopefully lead to

some hidden vault of everything that was missing. Etheria's machines, Etheria's weapons, Etheria's history.

"Grandfather," a voice came after him from the hall.

Hordak's blue hair nearly spiked when he heard his title being called. He turned to see Queen Glimmer V, holding a candle in her hand.

Five-hundred years, and they are still using candles, Hordak thought in his head.

"Your Highness," Hordak answered. He bowed.

"What's got you up this late?" she asked, stepping closer.

"I think you might be able to help me with this, actually," Hordak answered. He had planned for this. "I spoke with the Duchess of Dryl earlier today. She said she had no recollection of what became of Emily. You know of Emily, my wife's-"

"Your wife's companion robot," the queen finished. She smiled plainly. "Of course I know of it."

"Do you know what became of her?"

"During my grandmother, Angella III was queen, she passed a law that banned all weaponry. Etheria was in a time of peace, and it was no longer necessary for the common folk to carry around tools of war. The robot in question was once a weapon, so she was decommissioned by association."

"…What?" Hordak asked, imagining Emily torn to pieces and left to collect dust. His heart could barely take it. "How could they? Emily was repurposed and docile for years."

"If that would make you happy, Grandfather, I will do what I can to find her again," the queen said, her lower lip pushing up in a look of sympathy. "You may use what you will for the war effort. If you recall your crash landing from when my daughter rescued

you, the laser canons of Bright Moon were placed back into order. But once we've saved our planet, we all must comply with our laws. No weapons, and no excessive presence of machines."

"Might I ask why?" Hordak inquired, finally comfortable enough to ask. "It seems the decision to decommission Etheria's tech has led you to this vulnerable state in the first place."

"That may be so, but I can think of a thousand different reasons for why it is in Etheria's best interest to live without tech," the raven-haired queen answered. "As brilliant as your wife was, history has shown that her inventions only brought further violence and troubles to our planet."

"I beg your pardon, but her inventions helped shaped Etheria. She built machines that gave people their health back – that gave me my own strength back." He instinctively touched the pink computer chip. "Not to mention our own children, as well as countless others."

"Yes, it would be ignorant to say that invention has had no positive benefits, but let's not forget about the fact that her involvement with the Horde also prolongated the war that you caused."

Hordak was speechless. He stood blankly at the queen's face, trying to extract some sort of sense. He was never strong at reading emotions. This woman and her immaculate face made it impossible.

Not to mention the fact that she wasn't wrong.

"Prince Hordak, don't you want to be remembered as a hero? We all like you better that way." She smiled, dipped her head, then turned to walk back the way she came. "I'll see if I can find out what happened to your little robot tomorrow. Sleep well. Good luck on your mission."

- - -

After his conversation with the queen, Hordak didn't get much sleep. He figured it was fine. After all, he did sleep for a nearly uninterrupted 500 years. He had plenty of energy for the attack the next morning.

It was Ordara he was worried about. Sending a child into battle gave him a sick but nostalgic feeling. To his surprise, at the break of dawn, Ordara was bouncing up and down, itching for the fight. Hordak was trying to break his habit of associating the people of the present to the people of his past, but when he saw the zealous look in Ordara's eyes, he couldn't help but be reminded of Princess Frosta.

They were joined by only a few others. It was a mission that required small numbers, but high in skill. Queen Glimmer V offered up her highest-ranking guards. Hunters who lived in the Whispering Woods also accompanied them, as they were the only ones left who knew how to shoot. Granted, they shot with bows and arrows, but any projectile was needed to fight against the No-Home space pirates, who were armed with lasers and weapons from all across the galaxy.

If everything went according to plan, the pirates wouldn't even have a chance to even touch their holsters.

Near the edge of the Whispering Woods stood a tall gray tower, looking more like something out of Robot Island. It stuck out like a mechanical thumb. Nicknamed the "Temple of the Past," it acted as a place to store all of the machines that were banned from Etheria. The lethal weapons, efficient modes of travel, and everything in between.

Hordak peered through an old-fashioned spyglass, cursing under his breath at how foggy and unclear the glass was. He still could scope out the figures of two aliens guarding the front of the Temple. Yes, it was true, they had taken command over the Temple, no doubt drawn in by its high-tech relics.

How ironic, Hordak thought. The forgotten past is more advanced than the future. Yet, Queen Vee claims she wishes to preserve the past…

He put the thought out of his mind for now. He motioned to two lizard-like archers who stood at his back.

“Can you get a clear shot of them from here?” Hordak asked.

“Yes, Prince Hordak,” one said. “But where shall we aim for? The head or the heart?”

“It is difficult to tell what place is the most lethal to shoot these aliens,” the other said.

Hordak stared harder into the telescope and allowed himself to remember the thing he was trying to forget.

Those two aliens were living plants, with skin of bark like a tree. Thick white hair swooped down their heads and backs. Their long, pointed noses and long leaves at their elbows made them indistinguishable.

Yes. Hordak had murdered their kind before. He was just a young thing back then, not even 200 years old. He remembered switching his laser canon for a flamethrower, crashing onto their planet and setting their wooden bodies aflame. Before touching down, the skies of their home planet boasted twisting trees and sweeping grasslands which they made their home. After the Horde army was finished, all that was left were piles of black ash on the ground and trails of smoke in the sky. And, of course, the flag of Prime hoisted high in the winds.

Hordak’s shaking hand set down his telescope. He was a different man then, doing what Prime told him to. If he could go back, knowing what he knew about life and freedom now, he would have stopped himself.

Time travel was impossible. Entrapta had already figured that out years before Hordak met her. Hordak had to live with his mistakes.

Now, his mistakes had descendants. And it was his job to kill them again.

"Hey, Hordak!"

"Shhhh!" all of the soldiers shushed Ordara as she bounded her way into their hiding spot. The girl was followed by a few other guards from Bright Moon.

"Sorry," Ordara whispered. "We went all around the perimeter like you asked – those two are the only guards."

Hordak nodded. He studied the girl's face carefully. He studied the face of every Etherian who had joined him on this mission. Every color of eye, every strand of hair, every scale or scab on flesh.

Things are different now, he reassured himself. This time, I am fighting to save my planet.

"Archers, set your bows on fire before shooting. Those two aliens are vulnerable to open flame."

The lizard bowmen drew their weapons as commanded. As soon as the aliens on guard caught flame, Hordak gave out the next order.

"Archers, secure the clearing and stand guard! Ordara, you put the fire out, make sure it does not spread to the rest of the forest! Everyone else, we storm the interior."

The tiny squadron rushed out towards the Temple.

"Aw, but Hordak, I wanted to fight too!" Ordara protested as she stamped on the smoldering aliens.

"Your Highness, She-Ra may take my place," one of the Bright Moon guards offered.

Hordak had no time to explain to them that Ordara did not have She-Ra's powers just yet, nor any elemental powers. She was just

a girl with a sword, and she needed to be protected at all costs.

“Fine,” he said. To himself he thought, At least this gives me a better opportunity to look after her.

The door to the temple was originally locked by a keypad. As predicted, the space pirates had hacked their way through, leaving it wide open for pillage. Hordak prepared his own laser canon, ready for any heavy fire that they might be walking into.

The entrance to the temple was empty. The squadron’s boots tapped on the metal floor, echoing through the dark room.

“Woah, what’s that?” Ordara asked, pointing to a large pair of sliding doors on the wall.

“That’s an elevator, Ordara,” Hordak answered.

Everyone, except him, were all impressed by this revelation.

“We’re taking the stairs,” Hordak grunted.

The inside of the Temple of the Past was lined with a spiral staircase. Each level held a different dumping ground for the confiscated technology. Hordak taking the lead, they ascended the first level. Thankfully, no one had come to stop him. Yet.

The first level was filled with weapons. A quick search through the pile told Hordak that the aliens already scalped the most useful ones. He still gave a few to Ordara and the others, promising them he would teach them how to use them once they were back in Bright Moon.

The theme of the second level was more difficult to pin down. It seemed just to be a pile of junk. Hordak cringed at the sight of the discarded tech.

“If you had a grave, my dear, you would be rolling in it,” Hordak whispered, imagining himself speaking with Entrapta. Upon her death, she asked for her coffin to be shot into space.

“Who are you talking to?” Ordara asked, making a snort of a laugh.

Hordak tried to think of a clever reply, but became distracted by a certain spherical shape in the back corner of the dump. He ran towards it, stepping around junk pile after junk pile until he reached it.

A lopsided round robot, looking no different from any other of his battle robots from centuries ago. Hordak ran his hand over the hull, feeling the distinctive scratches and modifications, frowning bittersweetly at the layer of dust left on his hands.

“Emily,” he said.

“Prince Hordak, this floor is clear, are we to go up?” one of his soldiers asked.

“Yes. We won’t stop until we rid the Tower of the pirates.” Hordak looked back down to the decommissioned robot and fondly patted it. “I’ll come back once we are finished.”

“You really like talking to people that aren’t there, huh?” Ordara asked him as they took off for the stairs.

“You’ll find when you’re older that no company is good company,” Hordak said, chuckling like the geezer he felt like.

The pirates were all hiding on the floor above. There were only a few as they tinkered with some of the junk. With surprise on their side, Hordak, Ordara, and the others quickly took them out.

“That was easy!” Ordara shouted, wiping her sword clean.

Yes, only because I blocked every single one of your attacks, Hordak wanted to say as he rotated his stiff arm.

There was little time to rest as they heard the sound of footsteps coming from above.

“How did they find us so quickly?” one of the guards shouted.

“They must have had an emergency signal,” Hordak said, kicking over one of the pirate’s unmoving bodies.

Hordak saw this companions’ eyes growing wide. “Their machines can really do that?” they asked him.

“There is so much I have to teach you all,” Hordak said, “after the battle.”

A row of about ten space pirates poured out of the stairwell, lining up for a fight. Hordak perked his ears to detect if there were any more. All the footprints had subsided.

“This is their last stand, soldiers,” Hordak informed his own. “We stop them now, and we free our Tower!”

“Yeaaaah!” Ordara, fired up by his brief speech, charged right across and into the enemy lines. Any blaster headed her way, she deflected with her giant sword. With a jump, she knocked one down and slashed another dead.

Everyone else followed suit, firing their new weapons and keeping cover from enemy attacks. Hordak in particular maneuvered his way through the falling foes to get to Ordara. He blasted and knocked the skulls of any pirate he happened to cross.

It disturbed him just how enthusiastic Ordara was at the violence, but at least she was keeping herself safe. As Hordak almost reached her, he saw her crossing swords with a giant shark-like alien. She seemed to be winning.

Except for the tall figure that grew behind her, lifting a steel club.

“Ordara, behind you!” Hordak shouted as he aimed his laser.

“What?” Ordara looked up, distracted by the tall figure that got blasted behind her, leaving her vulnerable to a slash from the shark’s sword.

“Ordara!” Hordak shouted. Acting on instinct, his claw sank into the shark’s shoulder and the other claw slashed across its neck. Blood gushed enough to swim in. For good measure, Hordak hurled his victim into the metal wall with a heavy thud. Anger surged through Hordak’s bloodstream, lighting his movements with fury.

Hordak tore around to look for the next kill. He saw his soldiers being pushed back by the alien invaders. Hate filled Hordak’s chest and he felt a primal urge to move.

His vision went red. He felt fast. Before he knew it four aliens were lying on the floor, defeated.

He was missing one. Yes, the fool who was about to strike Ordara from behind. Hordak’s head forced itself back. His vision focused on his prey, locking onto the tall figure, still clutching at its burned shoulder.

Hordak reached for its neck and lifted the pirate from off its feet, ready to rip its head off.

Instead, Hordak froze. He looked into the alien’s eyes, finding himself looking into his own.

“B-brother…?” Wrong Hordak gasped. His face was twisted in Hordak’s strong grip, equally twisted by confusion.

Hordak didn’t know what to do first. He let out a yowl of fury and threw Wrong Hordak back down onto the ground. His head felt heavy with a stew of emotions. First, the repressed the feral need to destroy. Next, annoyance at seeing his old rival again. Finally, concern for the girl he was supposed to keep safe-

Ordara. Was she okay?

She was already being helped by one of the Bright Moon guards, who stopped the bleeding on a big cut across her forearm.

“It doesn’t hurt that bad,” Ordara said. Immediately after she cried, “Ouch!”

Hordak looked around to breathe a sigh of relief that all the other pirates were defeated. Vertigo took him over and the world began to turn. Hordak bent over to place his hands on his knees, breathing heavily, trying to bring himself back to focus. He hadn’t moved that fast or fought with that much fury in ages. He needed one long breather.

One of his soldiers walked over to Wrong Hordak, who was lying on the ground in disbelief at seeing his brother again. Wrong Hordak didn’t even realize as the soldier behind him raised a spear to his neck.

“Stop!” Hordak shouted. “We…we keep this one alive. For questioning.”

“Yes, Your Highness,” the guard said, obediently returning her lance to her side.

“Listen to him, that’s a great idea,” Wrong Hordak said, nodding along and sighing with relief.

Hordak looked back to the guard and shrugged. “Actually, it be best if you knock him out first.

The guard smirked before knocking the blunt end of her lance across Wrong Hordak’s neck. The clone was out cold.

“What will you have us do now, Your Highness?”

Hordak checked all of his troops. All were alive. Injured, but alive. He lugged his clone brother over his shoulder.

“We get what we came here for.”

The top level of the Temple of the Past was more of a hangar than anything. Spacecraft of all kind was docked but kept in good condition. Hordak speculated that this is what the pirates were

working on the whole time: making sure that the ships were functional before stealing them. Or worse, turning them against Etheria's own citizens.

Soon, Hordak, Ordara, the Bright Moon guards, the archers, and their hostage were all flying back home in a fleet of six ships. The autopilot drove each space craft back home to the castle.

Learning from his mistake of last time, Hordak made sure to send a message to Bright Moon that they were returning home victorious, so please don't blast us with the lasers again.

With a heavy sigh, he collapsed into the pilot's chair.

This was a victory. They stole back the ships before the pirates could. Now, they could meet them in an aerial battle. They collected a lot of raw tech and weapons that could be used to defend everyone on ground.

He even found Emily. He should have been happy. All Hordak felt was sick to his stomach as he replayed himself slashing through that pirate's throat.

"Oh, what are we going to do with you…?" Hordak mumbled to himself. "One disaster after another…except this time, you're alone once more."

"You're talking to nobody again," Ordara said. She sat cross-legged on the spacecraft floor, tinkering with the switches on Emily. With one arm in a sling, Ordara still found a way to activate the old robot. She wasn't even close to fixing her the right way. Hordak reminded himself to teach her later.

Of course you're not alone, you old fool, Hordak told himself. You saved their lives. You are a better man, now.

And for a moment, he did feel better.

Just for one moment.

Truths You Can't Change

Chapter Summary

After Prime was defeated, Hordak realized he had another rival out to get him.
In the present, Hordak has a revelation about the appearance of the space pirates. Odara finally figures out a way to access She-Ra's powers.

Chapter Notes

Day two of daily uploads. As I reread through my work, it is more apparat that writing this has become therapy for me.
Also a warning: in this chapter there's some light discussion on suicidal thoughts, but nothing too explicit.
Finally, sorry for not thinking of a more clever name for Wrong Hordak.
Here we go.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Year Zero ANS, except the fact that they hadn’t named this new age yet.

This was mere minutes after the war ended.

Horde Clone D5639-AK tried wrapping his head around what had happened. All the princesses were laughing and cheering, celebrating the fall of Horde Prime.

No, he wasn’t D5639-AK. He was Horak.

How? Hordak thought. How is that even possible?

His mind raced with questions. The loud noises and fast movements were a cocktail that fired up his instincts. His blood surged with the need to fight. Or run. Anything to ensure his own safety from his former foes…or were they his allies now? Maybe

they were his foes again. Their common enemy was gone, after all. What did that make him?

Horde Prime is gone, Hordak thought, terror striking him as he remembered. I betrayed him.

"Hordak!" a familiar voice screeched. Suddenly he was usurped by her, the voice in his head and the face from buried memories. She clung to his arm and swung him around, laughing. Happy to see him alive.

His mind wiped of all doubt. Not because it was forced by someone else, but he wiped it for himself. This beautiful, intelligent, and wonderful Etherian was happy he was alive. In spite of everything, he laughed with her. After all, he was so happy to see her alive as well. What were the odds that they were both alive at the same time and in the same place, together? What were the odds that they made each other this happy?

Hordak didn't try to do the math. He was happy to be happy. And that was enough.

He barely payed attention when someone said, "Are we all, like, okay with this now?"

In a daze, he followed her around for the rest of the day. Well, more like she tugged him around everywhere like a wagon. A happy, clueless wagon that was fine with being tugged around.

Then a clone came running over with a smile on his face.

"Wrong Hordak!" Entrapta shouted, letting go of Hordak's arm and ran to meet the other clone.

Hordak…or as he guessed, the "real" Hordak, stood watching in confusion as everyone crowded around the other clone. He joined in the celebration as if he was one of them. That sobered him up. It wasn't as if Hordak was expecting to celebrate with the rest of them. For so long, he was the villain in their stories.

Still.

What gave this clone the right to stand among them, smiling, free of guilt, as if he was there from the very beginning?

What gave this look-alike the right to pull Entrapta away from him?

Probably because this "Wrong Hordak" was better than him.

The happiness drained out of Hordak, leaving nothing but a rotten pit of bile in his stomach. The rotten feeling crawled up to this throat, choking him, making his entire body hot with anger.

No, not just anger. This was a different emotion, the same emotion he felt when he was turned away from Prime's side long ago and replaced with someone else.

Is this all his life would be? Not being good enough for anyone, constantly chasing after affections of people he dared to open his heart to?

No. Entrapta was not Horde Prime. She didn't judge his worth based on his likeness to her. She was…something else.

Time would tell what all of it meant. Hordak was willing to be patient.

That didn't stop him from resenting Wrong Hordak. Even if they shared the same DNA. Especially because Wrong Hordak's DNA was more perfect and free from deformity.

- - -

Year 571 ANS.

Hordak held out an ugly sweater with thick blue lines zig-zagging through a faded pink color. One of his many great-great-great-great-great-granddaughters just finished knitting it for him. His lips curled at the sup-par craftsmanship. He wrangled it over his

armor anyways, hissing at the scratchiness that cut into his neck. The first thing he would do is teach the people of Etheria how to properly manufacture textiles. He missed the sleek, comfortable clothing of old.

Hordak was always physically wrong. A genetic mutation dyed him with abnormal coloring and deprived him of lasting strength. That was always inside of him and couldn't be changed.

Emotionally, he was also wrong, and it was all Etheria's fault. The princesses who made him feel guilt. The one princess who made him feel loved. The children and grandchildren who made him feel proud. His own reflection, which left him with nothing but shame.

Not to mention that awful sweater. All Hordak wanted to do was rip it off and burn it. He couldn't, because he knew how much it meant to his great-great-great-great-great-granddaughter.

See, right there? That's a perfect example of what this planet did to him. It made him worry about the feelings of someone he wasn't remotely close to.

He stood in an age in which Etheria remembered him as a mythical legend, needing his help, wanting him to be around.

Why should they? He was a fraud.

But if his wife were here, she would tell him that he was perfect just the way he was, and it was a waste to worry. Even if he was the only one who saw himself as imperfect, and all of his problems were all his fault.

Part of Hordak longed for the days when he didn't have to wrestle with such complex emotions. But here he was, about to deliver a victory speech to the crowd of people calling him a hero and a prince.

He looked down to the hand-written speech Queen Glimmer V gave him. She had impeccable calligraphy.

“I want you to read this out to the people,” she instructed him. “Be sure to put extra emphasis on the fact that the use of the weapons and spaceships are only temporary, and you can’t wait to bring us back to the glorious age that you once knew. The age of She-Ra Adora and the Second Princess Alliance. Oh, and be sure to add in anecdotes as you see fit.” She gave him such a tidy smile. She trusted him.

Hordak crumbled the speech and dropped it at his feet.

“Citizens of Etheria,” he began, and the crowd below cheered.

“With the help of She-Ra Ordara, the brave soldiers of Bright Moon, and the skilled hunters of the Whispering Woods,” he made sure to pause after each group on the list so that the crowd could cheer for them individually, “we have won our first victory against the malicious invaders that plague our planet.

“We now have the weapons, ships, and technology to fight them on their own terms. We no longer have to cower and wait for them to leave. We no longer have to run while they invade our towns, steal our property, and kill our loved ones. We will defend our home with honor!” Hordak threw his fist in the air, a sure crowd-pleaser. And it was, as the people below erupted into waves of applause.

“And when we have achieved total victory,” Hordak continued after another pause, “I will see to it that Etheria returns to the way it was before. In the spirit of my wife, Princess Entrapta, my friend, King Bow, and the First Ones who first blessed this planet with their technology, I will see to it that Etheria has a new age of invention. We will have the means to protect ourselves from future invaders, to travel with ease, and even touch the stars.

“It will not be an easy path, but it will be one worthwhile. In my long life, I have become intimately acquainted with Etheria. I can say without hesitation that the spirit of Etheria is one of innovation and change. With this war, we will not only free

ourselves from those pirates, but we will free ourselves, as well. Let us honor the past by making the future brighter!”

No applause. Hordak felt his stomach drop to the floor. Even his spot on high, he saw as the people of Etheria looked back and forth, unsure of how to respond.

Then, one person began to clap.

Someone shouted, “For Etheria!”

Another shouted, “Prince Hordak!”

The crowd was once again ignited with passionate fervor. Hordak felt a bit of pity for the people of Etheria. Their birthright of technology had been taken from them. Etheria just wasn’t the same without it, let alone groups like the Makers Community.

Hopefully, their cautious reaction was a good sign. The Etherians would soon return to being the people they were always meant to be.

Hordak stepped away from the balcony and returned to the halls of Bright Moon. He passed by portraits of queens who reigned only a measly hundred years ago. Should he hate them for their silly laws, banning technology? Their excess use of power?

Of course not. Every good intention comes with unforeseen consequences. If Hordak could forgive them for their misguided attempts, then certainly he could forgive himself for his own past mistakes.

“Hordak.” The voice came echoing from the hall.

Hordak stood still. He was expecting his. “Queen Vee.”

Queen Glimmer V of All-Etheria stormed down the hall, her heels clicking sharply with each step.

“That is not the speech I had written for you.”

“I know.”

“May I ask why you ad-libbed such nonsense?” she asked, seething in rage. “Did I not make it clear to you that I intend to keep Etheria safe?”

“By stealing from its people?” Hordak rhetorically asked. He shook his head, suddenly feeling tired. “I thought you wanted to celebrate the past, Granddaughter. Innovation is part of your past. It’s part of you.”

Hordak looked at the tan-skinned woman and her shimmering black hair. He allowed himself a smile, finally finding it amusing that the current queen was not only a descendant of Glimmer and Bow, but of him and Entrapta. The planet would never cease to provide Hordak with ways to amaze him.

The queen’s face flushed with frustration. “I only want to keep the parts of the past that are worth celebrating. The heroes, the traditions, the legends. Not the machines that made us lazy with convenience or violent with war.”

Hordak patted her on the shoulder in a fatherly way that he used to do with his own children, long ago.

“You cannot just pick and choose which parts of history you want to keep,” Hordak said. “Even the ugliness is worth remembering. How else will you learn from it?” The last part was spoken more for himself than for her. He turned away before he could observe a proper reaction from the queen. “Now, if you’ll pardon me, I need to deal with an ugly piece of my past right now.”

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One thing definitely changed in the past five-hundred years: Bright Moon now had a place to stuff its outlaws. Permanently.

Hordak entered the underground prison. Nobody stopped him. Which is a shame, because he already had an excuse prepared if anyone did.

The prison was exactly what he expected, if not worse. The tiny cells guarded with force fields reminded him of Horde Prime's ship, even down to the design of the walls. He walked past a variety of prisoners. A lot of them seemed to be poor folk who might have been thrown in prison for stealing fruit from a market. Many of them seemed to be of higher birth, probably people of some renown or education. But then again, their prison garb was all the same, so he could have been wrong.

What Hordak needed more than anything else was hard evidence to confirm his suspicions. Fortunately, he was going to get it from the most honest source of information possible.

He stopped when he saw the cell belonging to his brother. His clone had his arms chained to the wall, showing off his developed muscles with rock-hard definition. Instinctively, Hordak's hand reached out to grip his armor, thinking of the skin and bones that rested inside.

Now is not the time to get jealous, he reminded himself, glancing in the direction of a prisoner that seemed to be no older than Ordara.

"Brother," Hordak said.

Wrong Hordak lifted his head. First he smiled, then he looked angry, but eventually settled on a smile.

"Brother! I wish we could have met in different circumstances," Wrong Hordak said. "And I do mean, completely different circumstances."

Hordak opened his mouth to speak, but his jaw wired shut when he heard heavy footsteps sounding down the hall. Hordak turned to see a pair of guards in heavier armor than the standard uniform that they wore above ground.

"Your Highness," one of the guards said.

Hordak felt his mouth go dry. He tried to make a fast decision whether to fight or run.

"Might we be able to help you in any way?" the other guard asked.

Hordak exhaled through his snout a short breath of relief. But it wasn't over yet. He had to be careful with his words.

"Indeed you can. Have you ever heard the legends of Double Trouble?" Hordak pointed to his brother. "As you can clearly tell, this is a shapeshifter of the same kind, trying to imitate me. I would much appreciate it if you could escort me to a quiet room so I can…interrogate them."

Wrong Hordak let out a yelp.

"As you command, Prince Hordak," the guards said. They unlocked Wrong Hordak from his cell and forced him down the hallway to an interrogation room in the back.

"No, please!" Wrong Hordak wailed. "I am not a shapeshifter! I'm a terrible liar. Quick, ask me what my favorite color is. It's green! Err…I can't do it, it's blue, it's blue!"

"Silence," Hordak ordered as he kicked his clone into the dark room. He turned to the guards and said, "If you would, give me as much time as you can with this scum."

One of the guards bowed obediently and left. The other hung on a bit longer.

"Is it okay if I watch?" she asked, then suddenly gushed, "I'm a huge fan of your fairy tale…well, I guess it's not a fairy tale anymore. But it would be a dream to see the legendary Prince Hordak in action!"

Hordak tilted his head. "How about I give you an autograph?"

The guard squealed with joy. “Sorry, sorry, I’ll leave you to it, Your Highness Prince Hordak, sir.”

With a roll of his eyes, Hordak slammed the door shut.

“Brother…” Wrong Hordak whimpered, cowering on the floor in handcuffs, “did I ever tell you how happy I am to see you looking so well after all these years? It makes me wish I stayed among you and the others in Etheria.”

“No, you don’t,” Hordak said firmly.

“Oh, but I do! I shouldn’t have gotten all tangled up with these pirates…I should have stayed here with you and Entrapta and Glimmer and Adora and…oh, there’s too many to name!” Wrong Hordak sobbed. “Please, let me know how they are doing?”

“They’re all dead.” Hordak sat down across from his brother. Wrong Hordak’s ears perked up curiously.

“Did…were they killed during the pirate invasions?” he asked.

“They have been dead for ages,” Hordak said.

“What…but how?” Wrong Hordak’s eyes grew wide and teary. “Was there a plague?”

“They all grew old.”

“You’re joking!” Wrong Hordak scratched at his chin. “Etherians must have a short lifespan.”

“Unfairly short,” the blue-haired clone agreed, “but that is not what I’m here to talk to you about.”

“Wait, that means…” Wrong Hordak continued, “you had to watch them all die!”

Hordak sighed, feeling a headache pressing into his brainstem. “Yes, I did.”

“Oh, sorrow! That must have been awful.” Wrong Hordak sighed. “Now, I am almost glad I left this planet. Ooh ooh ooh, weren’t you married to Entrapta? I remember you just announced your marriage right before I left. You poor man-”

“All right, all right, I understand!” Hordak shouted. “When I stepped in this room, I didn’t expect I was the one to be tortured!”

Wrong Hordak’s lips pinched to a tight circle, alarmed at Hordak’s outburst.

“I apologize for raising my voice,” Hordak said, clearing his throat. “Why did you band with those space pirates? Are our other brothers involved as well?”

Wrong Hordak ran his claws through his long white hair. He had let it grow out over the years, reaching even all the way to his lower back. Yet another thing Hordak tried to not feel jealous over: a glorious mane of pure white hair.

“When the brothers and I left Etheria, we argued about which way to go,” Wrong Hordak began. “As you can imagine, we had a difficult time agreeing. It was so much easier back when we followed whatever Prime told us, but we knew that we could never go back to the way things were before. So, we split apart. Some were welcomed as settlers in other planets, some continued to travel the stars.”

“And yourself?” Hordak snarled. “Pirates? Really, Hordak?”

“I thought you were Hordak,” the pure clone said, pointing to his blue-haired brother. “I’m Wrong Hordak. Or as my fellows call me now, Wrongdak.”

Hordak’s ears flicked at the unflattering nickname. “I never liked calling you Wrong Hordak. It assumes that I am the Right Hordak.”

“Well, you did have the name first. You can call me whatever you’d like, whatever is easier for you,” Wrong Hordak said.

“Very well. We are getting off the topic. I want to know your history with the pirates.”

“Oh, why didn’t you just say so?” the white-haired Hordak asked innocently. “At first I joined the pirates because they were all so different from each other. It was like being among my friends of Etheria. And it was fun to live with a purpose again!”

“Pillaging and stealing from other planets?” Hordak asked, shaking his head. “Hordak, I thought that is the life we were trying to escape from.”

Wrong Hordak held up his cuffed hands. “We never take more than we need. We never shed blood unless to save ourselves. If our prey shows a sign of peace, we are willing to negotiate. Pirate’s honor.”

“I have a difficult time believing that. I have a young friend whose parents were murdered by your raids.”

“Oh.” Wrong Hordak’s ears drooped. “I am sorry to hear that. Yes, it is true that some of my companions are more zealous than others. They have a fury in their hearts, but they recognize the pain of losing a home. We kept waiting for a sign of peace, but your queen never offered one.”

“What makes you think that the people of this planet are up to standard on pirate code? Queen Glimmer V would have never allowed this to happen.”

Wrong Hordak threw back his head to laugh. He slowed down when he realized that his brother was not laughing with him.

“Brother…don’t you know?” Wrong Hordak spoke carefully. “It is the queen who invited us here.”

Hordak inhaled sharply. Yes, this is exactly what he came for.

“I must be going, there is much work to be done,” Hordak said, going to the door. “Thank you, Hordak. I will let the guards know to give you proper treatment. Expect me to return by tomorrow, hopefully I will have a plan by then.”

“All right…all right! This is exciting! Another epic quest on Etheria!” Wrong Hordak clapped his cuffed hands together. “Oh, and before you leave, brother?”

“Yes?”

“It was good to see you again.” The sincerity in Wrong Hordak’s voice was undeniable.

Hordak lingered just a while longer, keeping his red eyes on the door, reminding himself not to look back. “I am glad to have seen you again too, brother.”

- - -

The training room was filled to the brim with tech. Everything from decommissioned vehicles to scrap metal piled up in all corners.

Ordara was shoulders-deep into the empty husk of Emily, working delicately with real tools for the first time in her life. Hordak stood at a safe distance, lost in thought.

“How’s this, Hordak?” Ordara asked.

“Hm?” Hordak looked up.

“Am I doing this right?” Ordara asked, a bit of panic in her voice. “I don’t want to kill your pet robot and all.”

“Emily is not just a mere pet. She was like a first child to us. Second, if you’re counting Imp.”

“What’s an Imp?”

“A story for another time. Now,” Hordak instructed, stepping closer to have a better look, “plug that red wire into the matching red socket.”

A bright spark flashed. Ordara gasped and pulled away.

“You’re alright, Ordara. Now, douse the plug with the coolant. It is a substance that de-heats the system without risking electrocution. Plus, it prevents corrosion.”

A few minutes more minutes of tinkering and teaching and Emily’s screen beamed pink. Ordara screwed the metal carapace back on, and the robot was fully functional, rising to her feet, taking a few clumsy steps of life. She turned to Hordak, immediately recognizing him, and nudged his legs.

“Now…that is a sight worth staying alive for,” Hordak mumbled.

“Cool,” Ordara said, drawing Emily’s attention. “Can you teach me to make my own robot?”

“I think it’s time we direct your studies elsewhere.” Hordak flicked his head to the She-Ra sword leaning against the wall. “I want to ensure that you are at your strongest before we engage in another battle.”

“I’m fine, it was just a scratch,” Ordara said, looking at the scar on her arm from the battle at the Temple.

“It’s not just about fighting. It’s about healing. The She-Ra I knew could heal the body and mind from its wounds.” Hordak scoffed and muttered, “As much as I wished she let me die…”

Ordara placed her hand on top of Emily, looking right up at the tall alien. “Do you really want to die?”

Hordak looked down at her, not knowing what to say. For a child who was barely a teenager, she spoke with a heavy age in her heart.

“No,” he lied. “Life is always a better solution than death.”

“That’s what everyone says. I don’t think they really mean it.” Ordara picked up a wrench and fiddled with it. “It’s okay, you can tell me the truth. I want to die too, sometimes.”

Hordak gave her a sympathetic look. Of course there was room enough left in his heart to feel for this girl. “Ordara, your fathers would want you to live on in their memory.”

“It’s not just that,” Ordara mumbled. “I’m being stupid, can you forget I-”

“No,” Hordak said firmly. “This is not something I can shrug off. Why don’t you tell me what’s troubling you?” He sat down cross-legged. Hopefully he hadn’t forgotten how to talk to adolescents about serious topics. After eight turbulent children, he had better remembered something useful.

Emily walked over him and took a seat on his lap. It was an awkward position given her size, but Hordak would rather cut his arm off than push Emily away.

Ordara sat down. “I wish I wasn’t She-Ra.” She let out a heavy sigh.

“That’s all right,” Hordak said. “Many of us are given heavy responsibilities unfairly.”

“It’s not just that.” Ordara squirmed. “I feel like I…can’t be She-Ra.”

“Because you are too young?”

“No! This is dumb, I shouldn’t-”

“Ordara. You are not brave for hiding your feelings. You are not strong for calling yourself dumb.” Hordak sighed and remembered to pace himself. “I don’t want to force you to do or say anything

that makes you feel uncomfortable. But I also cannot help if you don't tell me what's wrong."

"Uncomfortable…" Ordara set down the wrench. "Thinking of myself as She-Ra is uncomfortable. Because She-Ra is always a girl. And I…I'm not a girl." Ordara's eyes closed shut. "I've been lying to you and Starella and Queen Vee and everyone. I'm not a girl, I'm a boy. I've always, always known it. And when the sword chose me to be the next She-Ra, it meant that I had to be a girl. And I can't live with that."

"Aaah," Hordak said, immediately understanding. He looked at Ordara's face, how she…rather, he, winced tightly at the revelation. Hordak must be the first person to know the truth. "You know, one of my own children was the same way. Born as one way, but was truly another. There is nothing to be afraid or ashamed of."

"But there is." The boy looked to his own hands. "If I tell everyone who I really am…they either won't believe that I'm She-Ra, or they won't believe that I'm a boy. And I have to choose She-Ra, because that's what people need me to be."

"Ordara-" Hordak stopped himself. "I'm sorry, would you prefer to be called something else?"

"Maybe…I dunno yet…" the boy mumbled. "Just don't call me Ordara."

What should I call him? Hordak wondered.

Of course he had an answer.

"Son," Hordak said, "I firmly believe that the power of She-Ra is not anchored to one's gender."

The boy raised an eyebrow at him. "Um, it's called 'She'-Ra, not 'He'-Ra."

“Yes, yes, but it would be best not to restrict yourself. Power can exist in all forms and from different sources. Magic is neither black nor white. And even if it is, then we don’t have to bother with it.” Hordak reached for the sword. “I would rather find our own solution than have you feel this way.”

The boy reached his hand out, and Hordak handed over the sword.

“Can I tell you something else? But it’s kinda stupid…”

“You are not stupid, son. Don’t you ever call yourself that.”

The boy looked at the sword and held it closer. “I didn’t get the chance to tell my dads that I’m not a girl. So…that means they died thinking that their son was actually their daughter. Do you think…they would’ve been okay with it?”

Hordak patted Emily’s metal hull. “It’s impossible to say what our lost loved ones would think of us now. But, if they truly loved us, they would want us to be happy no matter what. If this makes you happy, then your parents would be proud.”

The boy’s brown eyes widened with hope. “You really think?”

“Yes, son, I really do.”

The boy closed his eyes. He held the sword upwards and took a deep breath.

“I’m gonna try again,” he said. “For the honor of Grayskull.”

The training room was flooded with golden light. Hordak shielded his eyes and Emily skittered away. When Hordak’s eyes finally adjusted to the vigorous light, he caught a glimpse of a tall figure with dark skin and a massive wave of yellow hair. The indominable spirit of Adora, reincarnated into a grown man entirely different from her, but all the same.

When the light was swallowed up by the sword again, the boy was lying flat on the ground, panting.

“Did I do it?” the boy asked. “I think I did.”

“You certainly accomplished something, that is for sure,” Hordak said, blinking his eyes, stinging from the light. “How do you feel?”

The boy lifted up a shaky fist. “Powerful…!”

“Well, that is good to hear.” Hordak’s heart grew dark with a grim reminder. “There is something you need to know concerning our plan.”

“About the space pirates?”

“We are not just fighting the pirates anymore,” Hordak whispered. “Now, listen close-”

“Wait, before you start, I want to try out a name,” the boy said. “I want you to call me Odin.”

“Odin?”

“Yeah.” The boy awkwardly wrung his hands. “I always thought it sounded powerful.”

“Indeed.” Hordak nodded in approval. “We are going to need all the power we can have, and then some.”

Odin sat up, waiting patiently for Hordak to announce his plan. Hordak felt a knot of guilt in his throat.

Was he certain that Wrong Hordak told him the truth? If it was true, it meant that Hordak would be turning Odin against a mother figure, the closest thing to a parent he had left. It would also possibly mean turning Odin against his friend Princess Starella. And if Hordak was to fail in his plan, Odin would also carry the guilt.

Was it right to involve a child in a plan like this?

The sword of She-Ra still sat within Odin’s reach. In the blade, Hordak saw his whole life reflected back at him.

He swore that things would be better this time.

This time, he would have trust. Inside and out.

Chapter End Notes

Old habits die hard, like recruiting child soldiers or writing fanfiction wherein the villains become the heroes.
When I first made up the character "Ordara" I had no idea that they were going to be trans. I quickly became attached to the idea, because I believe that themes of self-love can apply to anyone in any situation. If only I thought of a more clever name than "Odin"...
Also, points for those of you who were able to guess the plot twist(s).
Stay tuned for the next chapter...it was one of favorites to write.

Hey Soldier / A Life Worth Dying For

Chapter Summary

In the past, Entrapta has just died, and now everyone wonders what to do about Hordak.
In the present, Hordak's new plan is put into action.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Year 71 ANS.

The news reached everyone's ears. Princess Entrapta died a peaceful death of old age. And so died the last living member of the Second Princess Alliance. All that was left of them were them their children and their memories.

And also Hordak, who hadn't aged a day since the war ended all those years ago. He was a mystery, but one that seemed determined not to be solved.

He hadn't left his room since they took Entrapta's body away. He even missed the funeral.

In Castle Crypto, a meeting was conducted among his and Entrapta's eight children. They were summoned to answer the question, "What do we do with Dad?"

Theora, the first-born and natural leader of the group, opened the meeting. She, like the rest of her siblings, had stopped physically aging at around twenty years. Thanks to their father's alien DNA, they appeared to be a group of young adults, despite them all being in an age range of fifty to sixty.

"I say we force the old man out," Theora said. "He can't keep squatting in that room forever. If not for his own well-being, then for his own sanitation."

“Oh, yes, I am sure he’ll love that,” muttered Colbalta, the youngest. “You only want him out of the castle because you still think you’re in charge.”

“I may not be in charge anymore, but who’s children are sitting on the throne of Dryl?” Theora asked. She pointed a mischievous hand to herself and gave her siblings a smug grin. “That’s right, my children.”

“Because your children were the only ones boring enough to want it,” said Umbral, the oldest son.

The next to speak up was Meteora, cranky that her most recent tour of space was interrupted by her mother’s untimely death. “Okay, okay, we are supposed to be talking about Dad here, not Theora and her boring children.”

“You say boring, I hear responsible,” Theora said unflinchingly, holding her head up high. The other siblings groaned.

“She’s making that face again…”

“That ‘I know better than you all’ face…”

“Well, I was always Mom’s favorite, so she would’ve wanted me to decide what to do with him,” Colbalta said. “And I say we just let the man be. He’s old and tired and all his friends are gone. He never even liked being around people to begin with.”

“So, you suggest we just give up on him?” Theora asked. “Besides, if we’re going to play the favorite game, maybe Dad’s favorite should decide.”

Xenona, who wore full body armor like it was pajamas, stood up. “In that case, I say we force him back in the lab. Let’s just make him build things until he feels better.”

“Ahem,” Umbral politely cleared his throat, “what makes you think you are his favorite?”

The bickering went on for almost an hour until the quiet one, Astral, spoke. That always got everyone else to shut up.

“H-have any of us even t-talked to him since Mom p-passed?” she asked. “Do w-we even know if he’s e-e-even alive?!”

Just as quick as they were to debate who has the power, they were debating on who should go check on him. Xenona’s insistence that she was dad’s favorite backfired on her, as they all voted on her to check on him. Xenona tried to insist that she was wrong and Theora was the best choice, but the other siblings wouldn’t budge. With a grand send-off, the Dryl Sibling Alliance sent Xenona on her way up the elevator.

With each floor she passed, the fifth-born called the rest of them cowards under her breath. It was easy to talk about dealing with Dad, but what was she supposed to do when she actually found him? If she even found him alive at all?

Hey soldier, Xenona told herself, time to be brave.

It was her mantra. It never seemed to fail her.

“Dad?” Her bionic hand knocked on the door. “It’s Xena. Are you in there?”

No answer.

“Are you dead? Knock once if you’re dead.” Xenona forced a laugh. Still no answer. She sighed.

In a family of eight siblings, each one became isolated in their own individual quirks. They had to stand out in some way. Theora was the officer. Colbalta was the baby. Meteora was the spacer. Umbral was the pyromaniac. Astral was the shy stutterer. So on and so forth.

Xenona? The soldier, of course. Always the strongest fighter, always the genius when it came to inventing weapons, or new suits of armor to support the family’s collective weak bones. Even

though Hordak refused to play favorites with his children, Xenona secretly believed herself to be his. He was a soldier once, too. They understood each other. At least, that's what Xenona always assumed, because their dad never talked about his past life. Still, she and her father always had a way of connecting that did not require words.

That's why she broke down the door.

"Father," Xenona proclaimed, dusting the rubble out of her long blue hair. "I just broke down the door."

She didn't know what to expect. After losing her mom – a thought that was for so long impossible to imagine – the sky was the limit.

It was worse than she thought. Her father sat on the floor in an ocean of tape recordings. His red eyes seemed dim, which she never even knew to be possible. His hair had grown disheveled and unruly, greasy tentacles that reached down his skull.

"Aw, Dad…"

Curious, Xenona picked up one of the tapes. In her mother's handwriting was a date written all the way back from before they started marking the years "ANS." Probably before Entrapta even met her future husband.

Xenona placed it back where she found it and sat next to her father. He didn't blink or even glance her way. He didn't even seem to notice that his door had been broken in. His armor was dismantled and tossed in the corner. His raw flesh looked more emaciated than usual. Were the scars on his body growing?

Xenona eyeballed the tape player held loosely in his claws. Without warning, she plucked the headphones from his ears and placed it over her own. She smiled as she heard her mother's raspy voice through the static.

"…so if I were to put Catra in the box with said poison, at some point there will be an instance in which Catra would be

simultaneously dead and alive! But that would be impossible to look at, seeing something both dead and alive. Considering the factors of my own perception and the chemical material, when does one reality stop and the other begin? I would love to try it out for myself, but Catra already made it clear she wasn't a willing test subject…"

"I'm guessing you've been listening to hours of this," Xenona said, taking the headphones off.

No answer. He didn't even look like her father anymore, he looked like a hollowed-out skeleton engaged in a staring contest with the wall.

"She was really smart," Xenona said. "I didn't understand even half of what she was talking about, but I was always good at pretending. As long as I could build a laser gun from scratch, she knew I was her daughter."

Still nothing. Hordak was spaced out into oblivion. But he was alive, Xenona could see his chest rising and falling ever so slightly.

She had an idea. She stuck out a finger and slowly moved it towards his open eye.

He caught her hand before she could give it a poke. He set it down, then returned to being motionless.

Xenona sat there in silence with him, not knowing what to do or say next.

"Xena," Hordak spoke at last. His throat was dry and cracked from being deprived of all sustenance.

"Yes, Dad?"

"Are there more tapes that you can find?" he asked.

"Why would you want more tapes?" Xenona asked.

Hordak picked another from off the ground and carefully read the label. “All of her experiments. All of her brilliant theories. And still no answer.”

Xenona spoke carefully, “Answers to what, Dad?”

The tape slid from Hordak’s claws. “What happens after we die?”

- - -

“I have reason to believe that Queen Glimmer V is responsible for the appearance of the space pirates and is the cause for their elongated stay. I also suspect she has become corrupted by her power as queen and could be a danger to us all. Emily and I will investigate the castle and look for direct evidence. Odin, I need you to find your friend Princess Starella and think of a way to tell her this without scaring her. If I am wrong about this, then I will take full responsibility and punishment for treason. If I am right… then we are going to need her support.”

Odin kept running Hordak’s instructions through his mind. So much was happening at once, it was hard to keep focusing on what was in front of him.

“Queen Glimmer V is responsible for the appearance of the space pirates.”

How? Why? When? It made no sense at first glance. But when Odin really thought about it, Queen Vee always did seem like she was the type to hold secrets. But was that really true?

“Find your friend Princess Starella and think of a way to tell her this without scaring her.”

Ummm…how is that even possible? Starella was scared of everything, especially her mom. The only place Starella was ever happy was when they were outside the castle. Odin could take her there, but that would mean being further away from Hordak and Emily. What if something went wrong and they needed his help?

“If I am wrong about this, then I will take full responsibility and punishment for treason.”

Odin wanted Hordak to be wrong. This all had to be just a lie crafted by the space pirates. Odin was chosen as the next She-Ra so he could use the powers to free their planet from invaders. Just as it was in the past. That is how the story was supposed to go, right? A hero rises again to fight the forces of evil that threaten peace to their home. A hero wasn’t supposed to fight their own queen.

“Ordara.”

Odin’s spine shuddered when he heard his dead name. He hadn’t even the time to figure out who he was going to tell and when. There was already so much he had to think about.

Odin turned to see Queen Glimmer V and Princess Starella.

“I thought you were with Hordak,” the queen said.

“Oh. Right!” Odin squeaked, his face burning. “I was. But I’m not anymore! He’s not here.”

Queen Vee tilted her head back and made a face. She always made faces that Odin thought were funny. It made her look like less of a queen to him and more like a mom.

“Where is he now?” the queen asked.

“He’s uh…still in the training room I think. He asked me to go grab some food.”

“All right. Well, I was just on my way to speak to him. I can have a servant fetch you some food so you may join us.”

“No, it’s special food. Special food for Emily. I need oil,” Odin added quickly. “It should be in the scrap pile in the Temple of the Past. Starella, can you help warp me there?”

"Uh…" Starella couldn't even get a word in before Odin grabbed onto her arm and dragged her away.

"I'll see you later, Queen Vee!" Odin shouted back. When they rounded a corner, he whispered in Starella's ear, "Just warp us outside the castle."

"What?"

"Shh! Just do it, I'll explain everything."

Once they were warped outside, Starella shouted, "Ordara, what's going on? You're hiding something from Mom, I know it."

"You're right, I am," Odin said, thinking he sounded cool. "Also can you call me Odin now?"

"Um…okay, why?"

"I'll tell you later, just do it. Something bigger is gonna happen."

Odin went on to explain the situation as best he could, quoting word-from-word what Hordak told him. His words fell apart as he watched his friend's face twist into fear and disgust.

"Ordara what are you talking about?!" Starella yelled. "Stop saying that, you're crazy!"

"I'm not crazy."

"Then Grandpa…" the princess corrected herself. "Then Hordak is crazy. My mom is doing everything she can to make us safe. Those pirates are evil."

"Hordak is not crazy, he's been around a lot longer than any of us."

"Just because he's older doesn't mean he's smarter."

"Just because your mom is a queen doesn't mean she's a good one," Odin snapped back. "And at least Hordak called me 'Odin'

when I asked him to."

"Odin – Ordara – whatever your name is, this is all so dumb! I need to get to magic practice."

"No, Starella, I need your help." Odin tugged on his friend's arm to keep her from walking away.

"No! I'm warping out of here."

"The prison!" Odin shouted.

"Wha-?"

With a shimmer of light, the two kids were gone. They reappeared on the cold floor of Bright Moon's underground prison.

"Great, you messed up my warp, thanks a lot!" Starella huffed.

"No, this is exactly where we need to be." Odin looked down the hall. "We need to find Hordak's brother and help him escape, and he'll take us to the pirates, and maybe he can call them off."

"Gaaah!" Starella cried, squeezing her head between her hands. "What if he's lying to you? My mom has done nothing but help you and you're acting like she hasn't!"

"Hordak has done more for me in the past week than she has for the past year." Odin shook his friend's shoulder. "Star, he's helped me become She-Ra."

"Wh…what?" Starella opened her eyes.

In Odin's head, Hordak's words echoed.

"She-Ra is an icon. A leader. When people look to her, they have an instinct to follow."

No, She-Ra is more than that, Odin thought, She-Ra is proof.

He placed his hand on the sword. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

- - -

Hordak ran his hands on the walls, feeling for something. Anything. Some sort of fault, or panel. Something he could break open and reveal a network of wires that Emily could connect into.

Nothing. Bright Moon was pristine and flawless. If he ripped through any of the walls, all he would find would be wood and plaster.

I have gone cracked, Hordak thought to himself as he stared intensely at a blank wall. I'm wrong about Queen Glimmer Vee, of course she doesn't have a corrupt agenda. This is probably just latent instincts telling me to dethrone and usurp her power. You're no better than you were eight-hundred years ago!

Hordak slammed his fist into the wall. He regretted it for a second, as it would give away his position, and soon he would be flanked by royal guards or fawning family members.

Let them come, Hordak thought with a sigh. You're no good to anybody like this. You're better off dead.

There it was again. Like a needle sent down the brainstem and into the heart. The old fear.

Why didn't he just kill himself when Entrapta died? It's not as if he had anything to live for anyways. All of his other friends were gone. His children's children were all grown up. Nobody needed him around. If someone told him he was wanted, he knew it had to be a lie.

Yet, every time he stepped too close to something that would take his life, he hesitated. If he were to die, what would be waiting for him on the other side? An eternity of torment for his past wrongs? A dark abyss of nothingness? Or, just maybe, a paradise where all his loved ones were, where everyone was happy and fine.

Unlikely. The fear of death was stronger than his fear of living alone.

Now here he was, actively conspiring against the queen. Maybe they would end up killing him anyways.

Hordak's chain of thought was broken by a nudge on his leg. He looked down to see Emily looking up at him, her long legs tapping the floor with impatience.

He crouched down. "Emily, can you scan the castle? Try and find any hidden rooms or secret passageways."

Emily stood still, all of her legs stamping on the ground at once. Then, she rotated away from him.

Hordak knew that behavior. That indicated she was angry. But why?

"Oh," Hordak said, "I think I know. I forgot about you, didn't I?"

Emily's antenna twitched.

Hordak rubbed his hand across his face, saddened by this revelation. Their first child.

"Emily, I'm sorry I left you alone all these years. I promise, I won't ever again. Not as long as I'm still alive. I'll keep you safe, always."

Emily turned around, reached a leg out, and tapped Hordak on the knee. He was forgiven.

Next, Emily stood upright, focusing her scanner on all of the castle. She was a bit slow from having been just booted up. Hordak began to bite his claw as he heard voices coming from the hallway. He would be caught if they waited any longer. His mind raced quickly to think of an excuse.

Then, Emily made a "ping" sound. She took off down the hallway, thankfully in the opposite direction of the voices, and Hordak followed. They winded corner after corner until they ended at the library.

“The library? I already checked this room. Unless…?” Hordak watched Emily as she walked over to the fireplace, perched up against the wall, and began knocking artifacts off of the mantle.

“You had better be right, otherwise we have a mess to deal with,” Hordak teased the robot.

When the mantle was cleared, Hordak saw a button.

“Well, I feel like a genius,” he grumbled, remembering how he tediously tried to pluck every single book looking for a secret lever. It was always books. Why didn’t he think of the fireplace?

He pressed the button and a panel opened next to it. Before Hordak could properly view all of the switches, Emily plugged herself in and began beeping and whirring. In a moment, a hatch behind the fireplace opened.

Hordak smiled with pride and patted the robot. “Good work, Emily.”

He crouched and entered into the fireplace, trying not to inhale too much soot. This was it, the test of whether or not he was crazy. But if he was right, it meant that he had the queen to deal with.

- - -

Hordak was expecting a quick crawl through the tunnel, nothing too long or elaborate.

By the time he emerged out of the other side, however, not only was he black with soot, he was nearly ripped apart by magnets, and had a deep cut at his hip.

The magnets were the most difficult to deal with. When he crossed that short field, he had to abandon his armor and warn Emily away.

“You can’t pass here, this magnet is too strong,” he said, shooing her away. “It could shut you down or worse. Leave!”

The robot slowly backed away, hesitant to abandon him.

“I promised I wouldn’t leave you alone,” Hordak said with a weak smile. “I intend to keep that promise.”

Finally, she turned away. Whatever this labyrinth was, it was designed to keep all tech out.

Hordak was spat out at the other end of the tunnel. His exposed arms ached, he gagged with the soot, and couldn’t find anything to stop the bleeding from where he was cut. He wiped his hand on the ground, not the most effective method at cleaning himself, and pressed it to the bleeding wound. He was a mess, but he made it.

He stood up.

It took him a long time to process what he was seeing.

It was like he was back in time in his old lair white he was in control of his Horde army.

Piles of junk and tech thrown about everywhere. Massive screens, many dedicated to recording the goings-on in the kingdom. He could see into the rooms of everywhere in the castle and even homes of civilians.

A giant underground signal, which Hordak imagined she used to communicate with the pirates in space.

Blue-glowing test tubes lined the walls with flesh-bound lifeforms twitching inside. Hordak approached one carefully. The strange, fetus-like forms looked like young versions of the queen. In other words, they looked like Starella.

“Oh, no,” he said.

Finally, in the middle, a large bomb, even larger than himself. There was no way it couldn't be a bomb.

"Oh, no no no."

Hordak quickly pored over some notes that were left scattered about, trying to get as much information as he could. He realized he didn't have the time and stuffed them in his pockets. He had to get back to Emily and Odin as fast as he could.

When he turned around, Queen Glimmer V was there watching him.

"I really wish you hadn't done this, Grandfather," she said, shaking her head.

"Glimmer," Hordak said, saying the queen's given name for the first time. "Can you explain to me what this room is?"

"I'm much more interested in what you think." The queen's voice was broken and sad. Her face looked tired as if she hadn't slept in years. Even her raven hair seemed to have lost its shine.

"What I think?" Hordak looked around for some sort of makeshift weapon. He had no guess what she was planning, but he had to be prepared. "I think that the former queens of Bright Moon have slowly been usurping power. First by reshaping the Etherian princesses into duchesses. Next, by confiscating guns and technology to stop any progress in society. And now…" He stopped at one of the tubes. "Now you're cloning yourself to ensure the status quo is passed on. Is that right?"

She nodded. "It is pretty obvious, now that you can see my lair. That's why I didn't want anybody coming in here." She stepped closer.

"Does your daughter know?" Hordak asked, trying to direct her attention away from him.

She shook her head.

“But what about the space pirates?” Hordak asked, looking behind him to the large signal in the back.

“We made a deal,” the queen said. “They got to clean up all the tech off of our planet and leave us with a blank slate. They went farther than I wanted.”

“Why didn’t you stop them? It seems you had the power and influence to do this all along,” Hordak said.

“Because to do that would mean admitting I was wrong. And I am. I was wrong about a lot of this.” She gestured to the entirety of her dark lair. She walked over to the bomb. “But I’m not wrong about this. With this, I’ll start it all over from scratch. Build the world back from the ground-up. No more pirates, no more tech, no more errors. It can be just like the old glory of the past.”

“Glimmer. Granddaughter.” Hordak was a clone designed to kill. He was designed to take orders. He was designed to think in a hivemind, never negotiating or questioning anything. If there was any a test of how much he learned about people and emotions, it was this. “Don’t think of it as being wrong. Think of it as a mistake. If imperfections make us beautiful, then mistakes make us real. We can grow and learn from them. Do you know what I think when I see all of this?”

“What do you see?”

“I see me,” Hordak stressed. “Someone so obsessed with perfection and power that stops them from growing. Someone obsessed with the past so that it blinds them from what’s right in front of their eyes. You’re not alone, granddaughter. No matter how many boxes you force yourself into, you are never alone.” He offered her a hand. “Come on. Let’s get out of here. Let’s try and negotiate with those pirates.”

“You really think we can?” the queen asked, staring at his hand.

“You’re not just the granddaughter of Hordak and Entrapta, but also of the first Queen Glimmer and King Bow. Fixing things runs

in our family.”

“You’re right.” She reached behind her back and pulled out a short metal tube. She pressed a button and a staff of crackling blue electricity shot out. “I’m going to fix things my own way.” She took a battle stance, ready to fight.

“I take it all back,” Hordak said, backing away and trying to look for a weapon. “You’re not like me. You’re crazy.”

The queen ran towards him, swinging the blue lightning. Like claws, the sparks reached for him. Hordak couldn’t escape the energy that wrapped around him, electrocuting him to his core. When it released him, he fell to the floor with a heavy thud. Hordak could smell his own skin burning.

“Some legends are better off just that,” Queen Glimmer said. “Legends.”

Before he could make another move, Hordak’s vision went black and his head hit the floor.

Chapter End Notes

I may have gone too far in a few places.
As fun it would have been to go into detail on the eight Entrapdak children and their little quirks, I had to cut that section short. Originally, Theora was going to be the one to confront Hordak, since she's the one we are the most familiar with. But as a middle child myself I thought it would be fun to give a different kid a spotlight.
It was a coincidence that I wrote "Xenona" in a list of names for potential Entrapdak babies. Was it a coincidence that I chose that one to be the star of her own flashback? You decide.
Last chapter tomorrow. Hope I don't disappoint.

At Last

Chapter Summary

Hordak has a question.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Year One ANS.

Home at last in Dryl. Hordak had spent the past few months there, but now it finally was starting to feel like home. Waking up next to Entrapa in their quiet castle, spending their days experimenting and tinkering with whatever they felt like. Occasionally, they were called to meetings with the Princess Alliance, or their help was requested for certain projects in rebuilding Etheria. Around them, Hordak still did not feel welcomed, but that didn't stop him from wanting to change.

He wasn't alone in how he felt. Sometimes, being around others got too much for Entrapta to handle as well. In which case, they could retreat back to their home, happily living by themselves and on their own terms. Science without politics. Love without condition.

His heart full of hope, Hordak was looking forward to the future. For the first time in his life, he felt truly free.

That morning, he woke up alone. Entrapta left a note saying that she got up early and couldn't get an idea out of her head, so she would be in the workshop. In the quiet moments looking up at the ceiling, Hordak dared to ask himself the question: what next?

The Princess Alliance – he hesitated to call them his friends just yet – but they were doing this thing called "getting married."

The last time he was in Bright Moon, he asked Catra about what it meant.

"Marriage is this dumb thing where to people decide to stay together forever," she grumbled. "There's this whole ceremony about swapping a piece of your outfit. I don't know, I barely just learned about it myself when Glimmer and Bow got married."

Hordak asked her if she would ever marry Adora.

"I don't think we need it," Catra said. "I mean, I think that we love each other is enough. Who cares if everyone else knows about it?"

The thought had been rolling around in his head, like a pebble stuck in his boot. His heart beat with a nervous excitement, the palms of his hands grew damp.

He wished he had one fifth of Catra's confidence that their love was enough. He wasn't sure how Entrapta would react. But he had to know.

Before getting up to leave the bedroom, Hordak dug around his old things to look for something. Once he had found it, he rolled it into a ball and tucked it behind his back.

He found Entrapta in the workshop, as she said. He had absolutely no clue of what she was building, but it looked impressive enough, as she welded two giant pieces of metal together with her industrial-sized blowtorch.

"Entrapta!" Hordak shouted to get her attention.

She turned the blowtorch off and flipped her mask up. "Hi, Hordak!" Using her long hair, she climbed down the structure to his level. He kissed her on the forehead. She perched up and kissed him on the lips. It was their routine. They had to do it at least once in the morning and at least once at night.

“Oooooh! I can’t wait to tell you about my newest invention,” Entrapta gushed. “It came to me in a dream – literally!”

“I will be happy to hear it,” Hordak said. “But before you do… there is something I must ask you.” He swallowed, and his throat felt sharp as if it was full of razors.

Her ruby eyes widened with curiosity. No going back now. “What is it?”

“I…ahem,” Hordak cleared his throat. “I was considering…that…”

What was he doing? He suddenly doubted everything, from how much he had grown in the past few years and how much they had been through together. Why would she ever want to spend eternity with an alien like him?

Entrapta’s brows furrowed with concern. “Hordak, I don’t understand. Is something wrong?”

“N-no! At least, I hope not,” Hordak said. “I was wondering if you…would have any interest in…partaking in a marriage ceremony? With me?”

Entrapta’s face blanked. She nervously folded her arms behind her, flipping her mask down.

“I’m so sorry,” Hordak said, his heart breaking. He closed his eyes and backed away. “I shouldn’t have presumed. I will leave you now.”

“No, don’t go!” Entrapta cried. “I am the one that’s supposed to say sorry.”

“What? Whatever for?”

“I…er, we kinda already did get married.”

Hordak couldn’t believe it. “What?”

Entrapta flipped her mask back up, panic on her face. “When I gave you your suit!”

Hordak placed his hands on the armor she built him. The pink computer chip.

“It’s tech so it doesn’t really count as clothing…but I thought it did!” Entrapta wailed. “When I built it for you I thought it would make us be married, and I wanted it because I’ve never met anyone who understood me as much as you.”

Hordak stood still, trying to process this information.

“But I guess it didn’t count because you didn’t know,” Entrapta said, her head falling.

“There is no need to fret about it, I was just about to ask you, after all,” Hordak said.

“Sooo…you’re fine that I gave it to you without you knowing?” Entrapta asked.

“Well, I know now, and that’s all that matters.” He took the thing from behind his back – an old cape of his – and fluffed it out. “I do not have much in regard to clothing, but I hope you will accept this.”

Finally, her face broke into a smile. All the worry she felt seconds ago was long gone. “Hordak, this is perfect!” She took the cape and rubbed her face all over it. “I can work up a real sweat with that blowtorch.”

He couldn’t explain why, but Hordak felt his heart warm up as he watched her tie the cape to her waist.

“There we go!” Entrapta declared as she tucked the cape in certain areas, so it wouldn’t drag too much off of her side.

“So…that’s it?” Hordak asked, quietly. “We’re married?”

“I think that’s how it works.” Entrapta shrugged. “I never bothered to learn.”

“Would you like to hold a larger ceremony? Perhaps a public one?”

“No,” Entrapta said plainly. “Do you?”

“Goodness, no. I’d rather not waste my time.”

They stood a few feet apart from each other and stared.

That, Hordak thought, is my wife.

Finally, he allowed his heart to become overflown with joy.

She must have been thinking the same thing, as she ran and jumped into his arms.

“Hordak, I love you!” she exclaimed. “I’m so lucky that I get to be alive at the same time as you.”

Hordak didn’t know what to say. It wasn’t often they communicated directly with their words. “I love you, too. You are the most precious thing to me now. I cannot live without you.”

And so it was. The alien and the scientist, united with love, from now until the end. Hordak wasn’t just thinking of the future – he could feel it. The physical sensations between them, the inventions they would build, the children they would create. How she would die in just a few short seventy years and leave him alone.

Wait, Hordak thought, why am I remembering the future?

He looked down to the small body pressed up against him. He could see it, but he couldn’t feel her weight against him, or her breath on his skin.

“Oh, no…” Hordak mumbled, “I’m having a dream again.”

“What’s that you said?” Entrapta asked, looking up at him. She snickered with joy as she said, “…Husband!”

“I’m dreaming. This is all a dream,” Hordak said. He tried to remember what happened last.

Watching Entrapta grow old and die. Five-hundred years of sleep and isolation.

Ordara. Escaping Robot Island. The crash-landing. Queen Glimmer V. Fighting space pirates. Wrong Hordak. Ordara becoming Odin, becoming She-Ra. The secret lab, where the queen struck him with lightning that stopped his heart.

He gasped in horror.

Not noticing his anguish, Entrapta said simply, “Dreams are just fragments of memories played in a random order. Scientifically, there’s no deeper meaning to them.”

“If only everyone else in Etheria had your sense of logic,” Hordak said.

Except that this wasn’t a dream. This must have been something else.

He placed his hand over her head and pulled her in closer. He buried his face in her hair.
“I missed you.”

When he lifted his head up again, Entrapta was gone. He felt an ache on the side of his face, the cold hard floor. He was in Queen Vee’s lair in Bright Moon, the queen herself walking towards him, weapon in hand.

Hordak slipped away again and he was back with Entrapta.

“So,” she said, “are you gonna help me with my new invention or are we just gonna stand here?”

Entrapta peeled herself from him and went back towards the mystery invention.

“I said I can’t live without you,” Hordak muttered.

“You did, just minutes ago,” Entrapta said, not looking behind as she picked up her welding gear again.

Hordak could feel the warmth from the blowtorch. It was becoming more real to him with each second.

“I was wrong,” Hordak said. “I can live without you. I just don’t want to. Life was better with you here.”

“Then what are you waiting for?” Entrapta turned around again, her face forming a sad smile. “Aren’t you gonna join me?”

It took him all of his strength to say it. “I want to leave Etheria better than how I found it.”

Entrapta sighed. “So, you’re gonna to make me wait again.”

Hordak gasped. Whatever this was, she knew.

“That’s a shame,” Entrapta said, “I have a long list of experiments to run with my favorite lab partner.”

“You’re going to have to wait a bit longer, my love. I’m sorry.” Hordak reached out to try and hold her one last time, but he could already feel himself slipping away.

As the world became bright again, Hordak came to with a thud. Pain singed every inch of his skin and rattled his bones. His head felt heavy from when the hit to the floor. He felt a finger poke his arm. Probably the queen testing to see if he was still alive.

He would give her an answer.

He threw his hand out and gripped her wrist. With a scream, he threw her down to the ground with him.

“Gaah!” the queen yelped as she rolled on the floor.

Legs shaking, Hordak stood himself up.

“I won’t let you destroy Etheria,” the prince declared. He kicked the hilt of the lightning-sword out of her hand and went to smash it. Before he could, the queen threw a leg out to kick his open stomach. Hordak gasped as he felt nails sink into his flesh. She pulled back her shoe, revealing retractable spikes on the soles.

“Don’t you see,” she taunted him, “it helps to keep all the weapons to yourself.”

Hordak couldn’t take it. He succumbed to the pain. She positioned herself over him, ready to give him another strike of lightning.

He imagined what would happen if he died. The secret would die with him. The queen would be left to continue controlling Etheria, even wiping out the population or do whatever she could to fulfill her delusions of perfection. Odin, Wrong Hordak, every living thing on the planet he loved would be lost.

Deep inside of Hordak, the fury awoke. Strength flooded his blood veins and forced him to move. He took the queen’s arms and stopped her from striking him.

Grunting, Queen Vee kicked out her spiked shoes at his legs. Hordak felt no pain and used her lack of balance against her. With a twist of his own arms, she was flung to the ground. As she fell, the lightning sword fell from her hand.

Hordak took the weapon in his own hand and pressed the button, feeling the energy radiating from it as the lightning extended outward. He swung and let it fall upon the queen, who screamed as she was electrocuted. When the lightning stopped, Hordak threw the weapon back, his instincts telling him to keep going.

Kill his prey.

Take her power.

He stood over her, claws out, and looked deep into her frightened face.

No, he told himself. You will not kill her.

Hordak felt the rage flooding free from his body, spilling out.

She is your family. You already saved Etheria.

Hordak's legs gave out, burdened by the weakness that returned to his defective body. He sat on the ground, monitoring her, making sure she would not stand up again. He couldn't move, but that was enough.

You are not a monster.

- - -

"Hordak!" Odin called out. The boy emerged from the tunnel and into the lair.

After Starella left with the other Hordak to make peace with the pirates, Odin ran back inside the castle. Emily found him right away and led him to the tunnel.

Odin emerged from the other side, sword raised, ready to fight. Instead, he saw Glimmer V on the floor already defeated, paralyzed and twitching.

Then there was the blood. Blood. A dark maroon-colored blood seeped on the floor, leading to Hordak's body.

"Oh, no!" Odin rushed over to his side. Hordak's bone-white skin tissue was burned in several places. His abdomen was punctured with several stab wounds.

"No no no!"

He never got to see his fathers die in front of his eyes. If he did, he figured it would feel something like this.

“I’m sorry I didn’t get here in time,” Odin cried. “Please don’t die! I…I…” He looked at his hands and felt only hate in his heart. “We need you alive! I can’t figure this out on my own!”

“Odin…” Hordak mumbled. His chest began rising and falling with struggled breath.

“Yeah? Yes?! I’m sorry I’m not strong enough-”

“She-Ra is not just a warrior…She-Ra is a healer.”

Odin’s shaking hands placed themselves on the hilt of the She-Ra sword.

“I-I can’t…”

“Focus,” Hordak said. “Remember who you are. Remember the love you feel. Not just for others, but for yourself.”

Odin closed his eyes and tried. He felt lost, looking for peace in a world so full of darkness. Then, just for a moment, he had it. That tiny grasp of love was enough. Before he knew it, he felt stronger, taller, more powerful than ever. Power rushed through him, from the very tips of his hands. He placed them over Hordak, and he, too began to glow.

When the light subsided, the power vanished from Odin and he was small again.

Hordak gasped with relief, as if coming up from water after drowning. He placed his hands all over his chest, fully healed.

“Hey, Hordak?” Odin asked.

“Yes, Odin?” Hordak asked, a blank face, expecting anything.

For the first time, the kid looked around the strange room. “What is this place?”

“You don’t want to know.” Hordak covered his face and rubbed his eyes.

“But you’ll tell it to me anyways?” Odin asked.

At last, Hordak smiled. “Of course I will.”

- - -

With Wrong Hordak’s help, Princess Starella and the No-Home Space Pirates began negotiating the terms of mutual surrender.

It was a long and difficult process that gave the young princess many opportunities to learn. The entire time, Prince Hordak was there to guide her, passing the knowledge of his long lifetime down onto her.

The Space Pirates left in peace. In fact, many of them decided to stay on Etheria, as the planet was in desperate need of builders, mechanics, and inventors. Like a certain alien years before, they found themselves rebuilding and making home out of a land they once destroyed.

Queen Glimmer V was imprisoned for her treachery. Her story was told to everyone, so that nobody would ever make the mistakes that she did.

The Noble Alliance became the Princess Alliance once more, as the power was returned to the rulers of the different kingdoms.

And of course, technology returned to Etheria. It was not perfect, but it never grew to be extreme as Robot Island, either. Thanks to the return of scientific advancement, many great things happened, making every struggle worth it. Among them, Odin was finally given the body he had secretly always wanted, and everyone around him saw him as he truly was.

The years passed on and a new age was declared. Once again, the people of Etheria marked their calendars as Year Zero, ANE. After New Etheria, the Third Age.

As they grew up, Prince Hordak kept a close watch over the young princess of Bright Moon and the She-Ra (who was considering a name change to the title). Many times, the noble families requested that Hordak himself take up the mantle as the King of Bright Moon. After all, he was the oldest and wisest among them. Each time they did, however, he politely told them no. His job was to help ensure that the Etherians figure out their own way to rule. Ruling over people was none of his business. Not anymore.

Odin and Starella failed at several things, but they succeeded in just as many. They continued to learn from their mistakes as they came of age.

The day came when Starella was crowned Queen of Bright Moon. Hordak was watching the whole time, standing in the background as the two friends gave the promise of hope and prosperity to their people.

And of course, the day came that Hordak had long waited for. Hordak asked Odin and Starella if they needed his help. The two grown-ups smiled and told him no. They advised he take the day off. After many years of work, he had earned it.

Hordak sat in the courtyard of Bright Moon next to a sapling. He figured this was once the spot where he and Catra would spend their days chatting while their wives were busy in the meeting hall. Once again, Hordak was left outside of the politics of Etheria.

He couldn’t have been happier.

I wonder what I should do? he asked himself, petting Emily as she sat down next to him. Perhaps I should go check in with Odin and Starella again.

As if on cue, he saw them walking by through the windows of the castle. As a clone, Starella had grown to look exactly like her mother, but she was nothing like her in disposition. She was a fair ruler open to new ideas. Hopefully, she had no secret lair beneath the castle.

Next to her was Odin, who remained her lifelong friend. Odin had grown to be a handsome man, looking exactly the way he ought to be. A warrior and an inventor.

Hordak couldn't have been prouder.

They don't need me, Hordak thought with a smile. They will do just fine.

He rested his hand on Emily and closed his eyes.

- - -

When Hordak opened his eyes again, he was standing in a doorway. He had a vague feeling he remembered the large room, but he couldn't place how. Was this another memory, or a dream, or something else?

At the table sat all of his friends. Catra, Scorpia, Seahawk, Perfuma…everyone was there. They were talking and laughing, not a worry on their faces.

Someone was missing. Hordak looked around for Entrapta.

"There you are!"

Entrapta ran up to him and swung onto his arm. Hordak hugged her back.

"Entrapta," he said. He kissed her on the forehead. She perched up to kiss him on the lips. Their old routine.

"You have no idea how long I've been waiting for this," Entrapta told him, exasperated.

"Umm…what about the rest of us?" a voice spoke up.

Hordak and Entrapta looked back to the table. It was Mermista who spoke it, waving at him.

"Hey, Big Guy. You coming in or what?"

“Yeah, I’m getting bored of all these guys,” Catra hissed, receiving a playful punch from Adora.

“You want me to come in?” Hordak asked.

“Of course we do,” Glimmer said. “I think you’ve earned it. Don’t you?”

He knew it was true. All of their faces were smiling with openness and sincerity. It couldn’t have been a lie.

More laughter came out of another room. Hordak recognized those voices as well. He saw their shadows on the wall. Theora, Xenona, Umbral, all of his and Entrapta’s children. Not to mention the children of everyone else at the table.

Everyone was exactly where they should be, happy and at peace.

Except for Hordak, who still was standing in the doorway. He knew that if he stepped inside, there was no going back.

“Come on,” Entrapta urged him, “you can help me with my latest invention.”

Hordak looked upon the face of his beloved, and at last, surrendered himself to peace.

“I would like that more than anything.”

Chapter End Notes

The concept of Etherians swapping pieces of clothing as marriage comes from an interview with the show-runners I read, pretty sure it's a popular headcanon now.
Also...I'm done! I wasn’t expecting this to happen at all. Due to everything going on in the world right now I haven’t been able to attend my usual therapy appointments. So I sort of used writing this to work out some issues, and it actually helped a bit. So I in a weird way, I’m glad I did this.
But now I’m getting a little bit of fandom fatigue. I’ll probably

revisit She-Ra 2018 in another year or so, and I'll no doubt fall in love with my beloved bat boy and his science wife again. In the event I feel any inspiration, I might even publish something again. Not to mention the other pieces I already wrote that I deemed unworthy for public eye…
But for now, it's time I take a break. If you made it this far, thank you, I appreciate you for taking a look. See ya.

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